1 Film

In this unit you will find out:

- how films use narrative devices, such as flashback, and camera techniques to convey meaning
- how audiences classify films by recognising their genre characteristics
- how institutions and organisations promote and regulate films
- how women are represented in films and film posters.

TALKING POINT

- Start off with an instant survey. First each person should write down their two favourite and two least favourite films.
- Now combine your chosen films into two class lists. Do the same types of films – such as adventure, fantasy, science fiction, romantic comedy and Westerns – appear on both lists? Were the same types of films popular with both boys and girls?



Genre

Did you find that it was easy to say what types of films your favourites were? If so, it is because you already know a lot about **genre**. You can also probably tell, from a few seconds of a TV trailer or even from a poster, what genre a new film is likely to be, and you will have certain expectations as a result. What film genre do these three words suggest: *Saloon*, *Sheriff*, *Gunfight*? You probably thought 'Western' before you even read the second word! Media producers rely on your ability to recognise genre when they promote new films, to arouse interest, expectation and anticipation.

ACTIVITY 1

1 Work in pairs. Make a table like the one below to show the characteristics of four popular genres: Romantic comedy, Disney animation, Science fiction and Horror.

Genre	Typical setting	Typical characters	Typical plots	Typical props	Typical themes
Romantic comedy		Young man, young woman	They meet, hate each other, coincidences throw them together ...		

2 Now share your answers with another pair. Add any good ideas that you missed.

In film, exploring the ways in which **genre characteristics** are used to create style and appeal is very important. Films are often a complex mix of genres – known as *cross-genres* or *hybrid genres* – to attract the widest possible target **audience**. For example,

KEY TERMS

Audience people who are consuming a media text

Genre a type of media text with certain predictable characteristics

Genre characteristics or **conventions** the typical features in a text which show the audience what genre it is

Toy Story (1995) seems to be a simple Disney animation aimed at children. However, it also uses the genre characteristics of:

- Science fiction – Buzz is a Space Ranger
- Westerns – Woody is a sheriff
- Adult comedy – the voices of Tom Hanks and Tim Allen deliver witty one-liners.

TIP

You can find out more about any of the films mentioned in this unit from Internet databases via Heinemann Hotlinks.

ACTIVITY 2

1 Look at the poster for *Mars Attacks!* (1996) in **1**. What genres are suggested in the poster?

2 Watch a range of film clips or film trailers. How soon can you identify what genre each one fits into, and if it demonstrates cross-genre (hybrid) characteristics? What audiences will each one attract?



1 Poster for *Mars Attacks!* (1996)

Science fiction

The roots of science fiction

Literary heritage

Science fiction is a genre that has at its heart some form of technology which is not yet possible, but which could be one day. Science fiction novels were popular long before film was even invented. Early sci-fi novels include *Twenty Thousand Leagues Under the Sea* by Jules Verne (1870) and *The Time Machine* (1895) by H G Wells.

Even earlier, Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* was published in 1818 when she was only 21. It was the first horror/science fiction story written by a woman. It told the story of a scientist who discovers how to make a dead man live again, with terrible consequences.

Early sci-fi films

With fantastic worlds, strange technology and almost magical events, sci-fi novels offered rich material for early film-makers. Some, such as *Frankenstein*, have been

made and re-made many times as film technology has developed and offered increasingly sophisticated and realistic effects.

If you asked a group of people to draw a representation of Frankenstein's monster everybody's images would probably be very similar. This is because they are familiar with the **film archetype** representation of the monster from the first ever Frankenstein film, made in 1933 with Boris Karloff playing the monster.



Boris Karloff as Frankenstein (1933)

The social symbol sci-fi

Because science-fiction narratives often include exploration, danger and new technology, they have been used to explore issues causing concern in society.

- The Frankenstein story was used in the 1933 film to explore the fear that men and women would become so taken up by factual scientific proof that they would stop believing in God.
- American sci-fi films in the 1950s and 1960s, such as *Dr Strangelove or: How I Learned To Stop Worrying And Love The Bomb* (1964), explored the fear that nuclear technology would result in the destruction of the world.
- *Invasion of the Bodysnatchers* (1956) seemed to be about an alien invasion, but was in fact about the McCarthy trials in the 1950s, when American citizens were questioned about their possible Communist sympathies.

ACTIVITY 3 EXTENSION

If you can watch *Invasion of the Bodysnatchers*, try to find out more about the McCarthy trials and then consider how the film relates to them.

The **blockbuster** sci-fi film

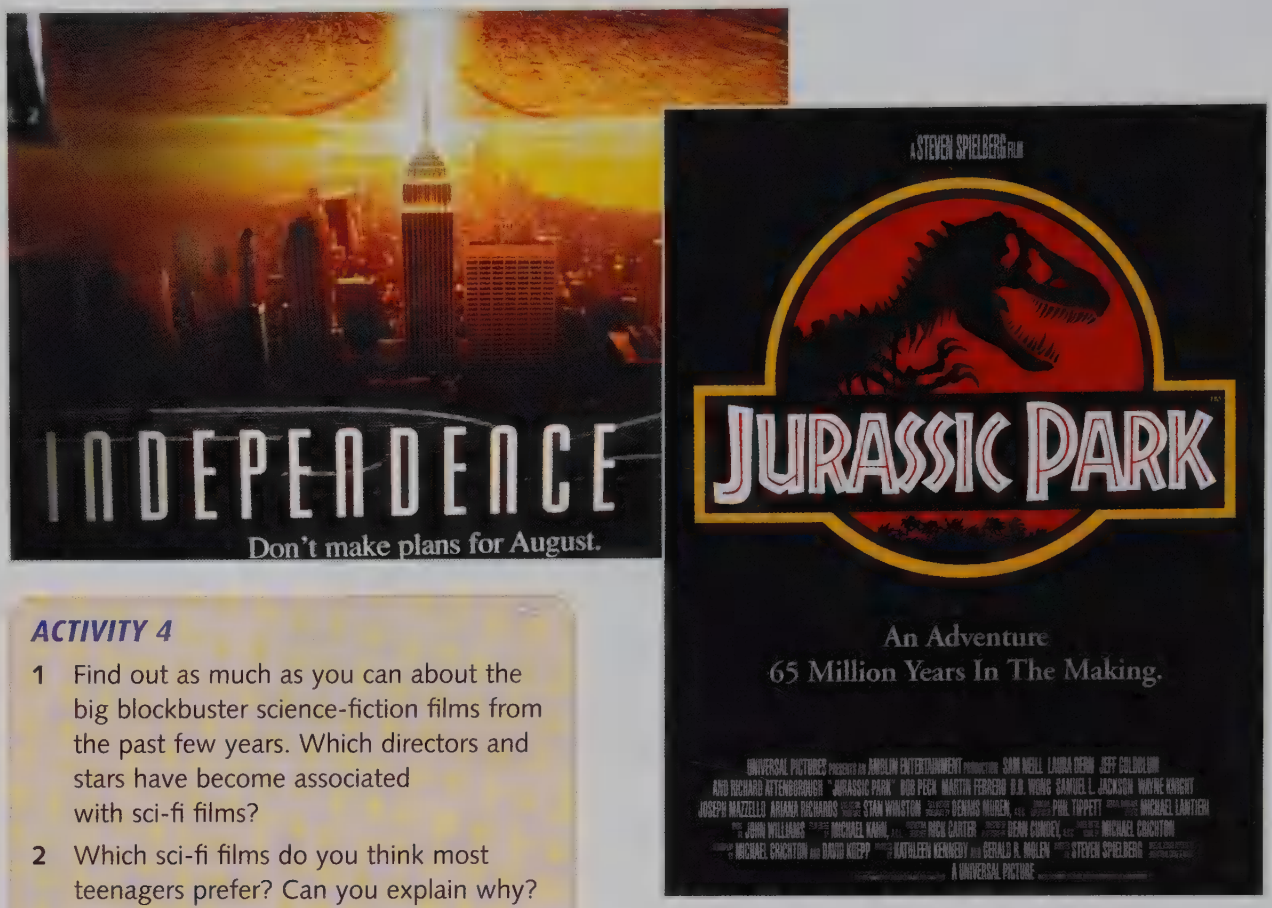
Until the early 1990s, sci-fi film was regarded as a minority genre which only longstanding fans watched. Then James Cameron produced special effects-driven *Terminator 2* in 1991, Steven Spielberg produced *Jurassic Park* in 1993 and Roland Emmerich wrote and directed *Stargate* in 1994. All these films were marketed to

KEY TERMS

Blockbuster a film expected to be a hit, so-called because of the long queues around the block to see successful films

Film archetype the outstanding features of a character, which other film-makers imitate in later films, e.g. Sean Connery as James Bond saying: 'The name's Bond. James Bond'

audiences as cross-genres of action with science fiction. With a big budget and special effects, Emmerich followed *Stargate* up in 1996 with *Independence Day*, and science fiction was established as a hugely exciting and action-packed genre for teenagers (3).



Sci-fi films became big hits in the 1990s

ACTIVITY 4

1 Find out as much as you can about the big blockbuster science-fiction films from the past few years. Which directors and stars have become associated with sci-fi films?

2 Which sci-fi films do you think most teenagers prefer? Can you explain why? Try to decide what the ingredients are that make a sci-fi film really popular.

Representations in science fiction

Representation is an important word in media studies. It means the ways in which people, places or events are *re–presented* to audiences. Representations of people are usually designed to make them as believable as possible, but if you look closely at representations of key social groups such as women, men, teenagers, ethnic groups, old people, etc. you will see that they are often quite **stereotypical**. Many teenage representations show them as being disrespectful, moody and selfish – this is obviously a very narrow view of teenagers.

ACTIVITY 5

1 Look at a range of film clips in several genres. Try to identify different ways that people are represented.

2 Make a list to show how similar social groups (women, men, teenagers, ethnic groups, old people) are generally represented.

3 Try to suggest examples of representations that are *not* stereotypical but seem to be genuinely convincing and 'realistic'.

KEY TERMS

Representation how people, places or events are represented or portrayed to audiences in media texts

Stereotypical showing groups of people in terms of certain shared and expected characteristics, e.g. showing women as nagging housewives

Propp suggested in the 1920s that every story had characters in certain roles: hero, heroine or princess, villain, donor or mentor and helper (see page 101 to find out more about these roles). Science fiction can represent groups of people in unusual ways by allowing them to fulfil unexpected roles in societies that are wholly invented.

Representations of women

Sci-fi has offered women real opportunities to be empowered and to break away from the more helpless 'princess' role. Ripley in Ridley Scott's *Alien* (1979) and Sarah Connor in *Terminator* (1984) were given lead roles who had real power and strength and were often responsible for pushing the **narrative** forward. It could be argued that such women play the hero role rather than the heroine.

ACTIVITY 6

In small groups, find out about some or all of these characters. Present your findings as a display of images with accompanying factfiles.

- Lara Croft in *Tomb Raider* (2001)
- Ripley in *Alien Resurrection* (1997)
- Princess Amidala in *Star Wars I* and *II* (1999 and 2002)
- Sarah Connor in *Terminator 2* (1991)
- Lyndsay in *The Abyss* (1989)
- Trinity in *Matrix* (1999)

Representations of aliens

One of the great conventions of sci-fi is the presence of some amazingly memorable aliens! Try jotting down as many as you can in one minute.

Sometimes taking 'human' form, sometimes robot, sometimes imaginative life-forms from other planets, aliens allow film-makers to explore different patterns of behaviour, language and customs. The essential thing about aliens is that they are *different* from us.

It is not hard to see that aliens are often used as a symbol for themes of belonging and being different. They can also be a way for film-makers to explore social problems, such as prejudice, in a subtle way.

ACTIVITY 7

1. Create your own alien. You can make it friendly or hostile, but you must label your design by pointing out key features that make it different from a human.
2. Extend your design by writing a paragraph describing how the alien responds to humans, and what would happen if it came to Earth.

ACTIVITY 8 EXTENSION

Other frequent representations in sci-fi films are: *scientists*, **stock characters** and *captains* or other leadership figures. Choose one of these representations and analyse their roles in one or two films of your choice, sharing your findings with the class as a presentation or display.

KEY TERMS

Narrative a story or account

Stock character supporting character who is often quite stereotypical and whose job it is to help the lead characters, to be saved by them or to die

Reading science-fiction films

Reading a film is similar to reading a book. First you must know the language, and then be able to work out what it means. Use this checklist to help you to look for the most important features in a sci-fi film:

- *Characters* (including aliens) will have clear roles and purposes in the narrative.
- *Costumes* are important – especially in future worlds.
- *Settings* are part of the created world and often involve **special effects**.
- *Colours* are important and are often symbolic, e.g. neon green often symbolises 'the alien'.
- *Soundtrack* is a vital clue to suggesting mood, theme and key moments.
- *Conventions* such as space, jargon, gadgets, weapons, etc. all build up the understanding of the narrative.
- *Special effects* may play a huge part – look out for animation, CGI (computer-generated imagery – see page 111), clever use of camera angles, action sequences.

KEY TERM

Special effects
exciting and dynamic visual or sound effects used to create impact in films

ACTIVITY 9

Practise your reading skills in science fiction. Watch clips from a range of sci-fi films. Make notes on the conventions, themes and characters as you go. Write your notes up as an essay or report.

ACTIVITY 10 EXTENSION

Prepare a more developed film brief (proposal), based around the following idea:

An exploration spaceship has gone missing without warning, and a crew must be sent to rescue them. Led by a female Captain and a male First Officer, the rescue ship is captured by an alien ship and taken to a new world where the inhabitants have very strange customs. The original exploration crew are also there, and the humans must work out a plan to escape and get back to Earth – but not without tragedy, love and an unexpected twist of fate before the end of the film.

1. Give your film a title and explain its meaning.
2. Cast the main parts and explain your choices.
3. Outline the narrative more fully, explaining all the interesting details.
4. Design the film poster.
5. If you are going to develop this work into a coursework piece, plan the promotion campaign for the film. This could include: storyboard or trailer, merchandise designs, soundtrack CD cover and DVD cover.



TIP

Keep your work from Activity 10 in your coursework folder.

Looking at narratives

Tzvetan Todorov devised a way of analysing narratives according to the way they move forward through different stages. He suggested that many narratives, regardless of their genre, could be broken into specific stages for analysis.

Todorov's Narrative Stages

Equilibrium – the setting is established, key character(s) are introduced and the storyline is set up.

Disruption – oppositional character(s) appear and the story takes a particular direction.

Recognition of disruption – the lives of characters and events are interwoven. Tension builds throughout this section, which is often the longest.

Attempt to repair disruption – the highest point of tension after which there is a change in dynamic.

Reinstatement of equilibrium – matters are sorted out, problems are solved and questions answered.

Emily was sick of waiting around for a wimpy prince to come and ask for her hand in marriage, so she decided to find one for herself. She soon came upon a dragon who was singeing the top of a freckle-faced boy's head.

Being a resourceful princess, Emily set a trap for the dragon and then tricked him into following her.

'You're just a silly girl, and even though it's hardly worth it, I'm going to toast you to a crisp and have you for pudding!' boomed the dragon. Just then, the branches he was standing on gave way, and he fell down a very deep well, his fire put out once and for all.

Emily returned to the boy. 'What's your name?' she asked.

'Prince Matthew,' said the boy.

'That'll do nicely,' said Emily. 'Where do you live?'

'In Happy-Ever-After,' he replied.

'That'll do nicely too,' said Emily. And with that, she and Matthew rode off together to Happy-Ever-After.



5 Emily and the dragon

Why, you may well be asking, is the children's fairy story in **5** in a book on GCSE Media Studies? The answer is that the **narrative structure** suggested by Todorov fits this story so perfectly, and there are many useful activities arising from it.

ACTIVITY 11

1 Create your own chart to show how the theory can be applied to Emily's story. The first two sections have been done to help you.

Equilibrium:	*We meet key character Emily, find out that she wants to find a prince for herself.*
Disruption:	*Emily meets oppositional characters: the dragon and boy.*
Recognition of disruption:	
Attempt to repair:	
Reinstatement:	

2 Work in a small group to find each of the stages in two films you know well.

3 Watch a short narrative – a cartoon would be a good text to use. Analyse its narrative structure by breaking it down into its five stages.

4 Think of your own simple story featuring a small boy or girl. Write a 50-word story that follows this narrative structure and read it to a partner.

Playing with narratives

Obviously not all narratives fit into the linear progression suggested by Todorov, especially if they are trying to do something different or unpredictable. For example, in the film *Back To The Future* (1985) directed by Steven Spielberg, a boy travels back in time to meet the scientist who invented time travel. The stages of the narrative in this film are not in chronological order. Can you think of any other examples?

The correct term for something that does not fit a recognised theory is a **subversion.** You may recognise these subversion techniques:

- *Flashback* – where a section of the film is referred back to, e.g. *The Hulk* (2003) directed by Ang Lee.
- *Flashforward* – where a section of the film from the future is shown before it would normally have happened, e.g. *The Matrix Reloaded* (2003) directed by the Wachowski brothers.
- *Twist* – where part of the film (often the end) is unpredictable or even shocking, e.g. *The Sixth Sense* (1999) directed by M. Night Shyamalan.
- *Parallel narratives* – where the lives of characters move alongside each other for some of the film without them meeting, e.g. *Independence Day* (1996) directed by Roland Emmerich.

KEY TERMS

Narrative structure the way in which a story is organised and shaped in terms of time and events

Oppositional characters characters who will play opposite the key central character, either in a relationship, e.g. the hero/heroine, or in conflict, e.g. the hero/villain

Subversion when a technique is used which does not fit a theory or the usual way of doing something

ACTIVITY 12

Divide into groups. Look again at Emily's story in **5**. Each group should prepare to re-tell the story, using one or more subversions. Change the original version so that the narrative no longer follows the same path. The following suggestions may help you:

- Flashback – start the story from the moment when Emily is facing the dragon.
- Flashforward – begin the story with a dream sequence in which Emily faces a fire-breathing beast.
- Twist – Emily does not have to be human!
- Parallel narratives – tell Emily's story side by side with Prince Matthew's (or the dragon's) story. This could make the audience feel differently towards them.

Audience positioning



Audiences enjoy texts most when they are really involved in them. When you analyse a media text such as a film, identify the key techniques that 'sew' the audience into it. When they are genuinely hooked into the text's narrative and development, it is as if they actually have their own position in it. You can see why this is so important – someone who is really involved in a text is much less likely to switch it off or put it back on the shelf. Here are some techniques that help an audience to become involved or positioned in a film or television text.

- **Point-of-view shots** – the camera adopts the position of a character within the text. This can be an over-the-shoulder shot, looking at whatever the character is looking at, or a shot from the point of view of the character. This is particularly powerful when the character is experiencing a strong emotion – the viewer is more likely to feel their emotion when taking their point of view.
- **Reaction shots** – the camera moves to an extreme close-up of a character's face to show their reaction to something that has happened (see **6**: Eddie Murphy in *The Nutty Professor* (1996)).



6 Reading facial expression is crucial to understanding a character's reaction

- **Insert shots** – this technique gives the audience extra or privileged information that one or more characters may not yet know, for example in a two-set scene with two characters in different locations. The audience knows what is happening to each of them when the characters themselves do not.
- **Shot reverse shot** – the camera alternates between two characters to show their building relationship (whether positive or negative), often as a conversation is taking place between them. This is a very common technique in dramas where the inter-relationship between characters is very important. The camera acts as a third person in shot reverse shot, giving the audience the impression that they are turning their heads from one character to the other.



7 These three images demonstrate the shot reverse shot technique

ACTIVITY 13

1 Watch a series of film clips from different genres. Identify as many techniques of audience positioning as possible.

2 Using a still camera, create a series of shots which demonstrate each of the audience positioning techniques. Display them in your classroom with an imaginary narrative situation written underneath each one. You can see an example in **7**.

Additional camera terms and definitions



A great deal of time is spent on setting up every scene in a film. It is important to position the cameras in just the right way to capture on film exactly what the director wants the audience to see. In addition to the techniques mentioned already, here are some other camera shots that you will be able to identify in the films you study.

Camera term	What it means
Establishing shot	The camera is set far back to show or to emphasise setting or location rather than the subject
Slo-mo	A moment which is replayed very slowly
Pan shot	The camera moves horizontally, taking in all the details along the way
Tracking shot	The camera moves alongside characters either using a hand-held technique or smooth dolly tracks
Zoom	The camera focuses in on, or out from, a subject by using a telephoto lens
Mini cam	A tiny camera is placed in an unusual place for effect
Steadi-cam	A weighted camera is strapped to an operator to allow hand-held but controlled movement

TIP

Using a chart or table to present textual analysis will help you to keep under the word limit.

ACTIVITY 14 EXTENSION

Watch the first ten minutes of one of these films: *Star Wars IV: A New Hope* (1997), *The Truman Show* (1998) or *Saving Private Ryan* (1998). Look for evidence of genre characteristics, narrative structure, audience positioning and carefully set up camerawork. Present your findings as a table, chart, report or essay.

Intertextuality

Have you ever experienced the thrill of watching a film and recognising a reference to another film? This type of link between two texts is known as an **intertextual reference**. Do you recognise the phrases 'I'll be back' and 'shaken not stirred'? Where have you heard them? Can you think of other phrases which you have heard used intertextually in films or TV programmes?

Intertextual references can be visual as well. You can find a good example of this in *Toy Story 2* (1999). The toys are riding around Al's Toy Barn in a Barbie Tour guide car and Rex the dinosaur is running behind them, his reflection clearly seen in the wing mirror. This is an intertextual reference to the scene in *Jurassic Park* (1993) when the T-Rex can be seen in the wing mirror chasing the tour guide vehicle – in this case, with the intention of eating the passengers!

Another example is the Robin Hood scene in *Shrek* (2000) when Princess Fiona fights Robin Hood and his men; she fights in the same style as Trinity from *The Matrix* (1999).

The story of *Bridget Jones Diary* (2001) is full of intertextual references to Jane Austin's *Pride and Prejudice*, although the settings and the characters of the heroines could hardly be more different. The basic storyline is similar: girl meets and hates boy but after many mishaps realises his true worth and marries him. Among other references,

KEY TERM

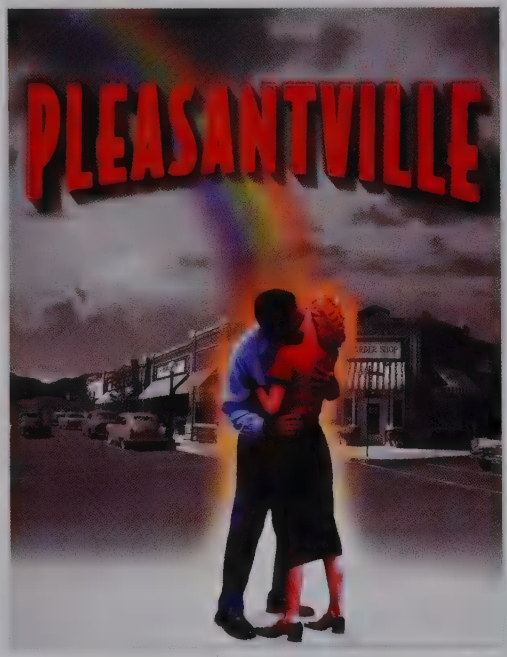
Intertextual reference when one media text mimics or refers to another media text in a way that many consumers will recognise

the hero's surname is Darcy in both stories. In case anyone missed the point, Colin Firth, who had played Mr Darcy in the 1995 BBC mini-series of *Pride and Prejudice*, was cast as Mark Darcy in the film.

How films are promoted: film posters

Film posters: giving information

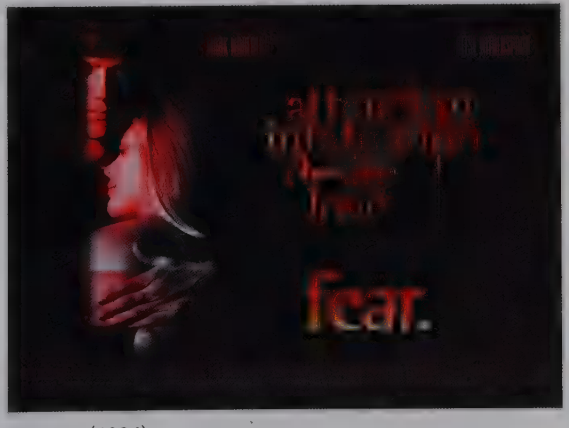
Film posters are hard to ignore – they are large, they are eye-catching and they are often intriguing. How well do they communicate information about the genre, characters and events in the films? Look at posters **8** to **11**, showing films featuring movie star Reese Witherspoon. What genre would you expect each film to be? In what different ways is Reese Witherspoon presented in these posters?



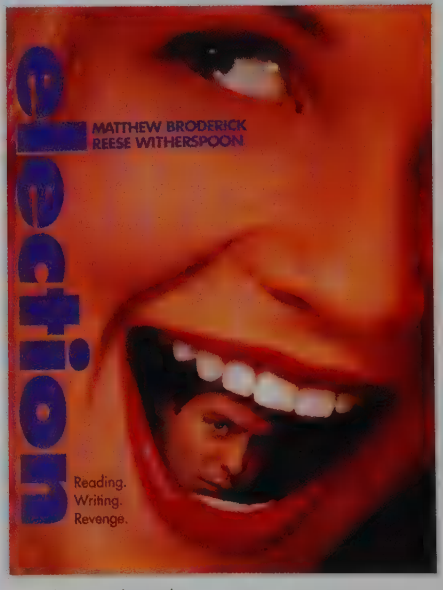
8 *Pleasantville* (1998)



9 *The Importance of Being Earnest* (2002)



10 *Fear* (1996)



11 *Election* (1999)

ACTIVITY 15

In pairs, use the information on the posters, both in words and pictures, to match these plot summaries to the film titles in posters **8** to **11**.

A Nicole discovers that her 'perfect' boyfriend David has a violent and disturbed side to his character.

B Jennifer and her brother David find themselves trapped in his favourite 1950s soap opera.

C This screen version of Oscar Wilde's play casts Reese as the young sweetheart Cecily in a comedy of manners.

D Tracy wants to be student president and uses some surprising tactics in this comedy film about the world of high-school politics.

Did you find lots of clues on the posters? Posters communicate information by the way the images are presented. The **gesture codes** of the characters instantly signal violent and disturbing events or romantic and comic moments. Other details, such as costume, location and lighting, also help us read the poster's messages.

A key message is the genre of the film. Next, the poster gives clues about the story in the **tag line**. Tag lines can become well known in their own right:

- The science fiction/horror classic *Alien* (1979) had the famous tag line *In space, no one can hear you scream ...*
- *Jaws 2* (1978) had the tag line *Just when you thought it was safe to go back in the water*. This was an intertextual reference to the first film *Jaws* (1975), which had been a huge hit. It reminds the audience of the terror of bathing in shark-infested waters.

ACTIVITY 16

Think of some catchy tag lines for these films:

- *First Victim*: a new monster, part werewolf, part vampire, hits town, looking for his first victim – a teenager.
- *No Way, Baby:* high-school heart-throb Jay is determined not to get tied down in a steady relationship. The high-school babes have other ideas!
- *Triple Deceit*: Detective Pacino is baffled by a series of murders until his new partner gives him some valuable insights. But where does she get her information?

Film posters: promoting stars

One way a poster can grab people's attention is to show pictures of the film's stars. The more popular the star, the more dominant their image will be in the poster. Stars are said to be 'A' or 'B' list depending on how popular they are. Can you identify the biggest **box-office draw** in each of posters **12** to **15**?

KEY TERMS

Box-office draw a performer whose popularity is likely to make a film successful; they are said to *carry* the film

Gesture code how a media text conveys a message using facial expression or body language

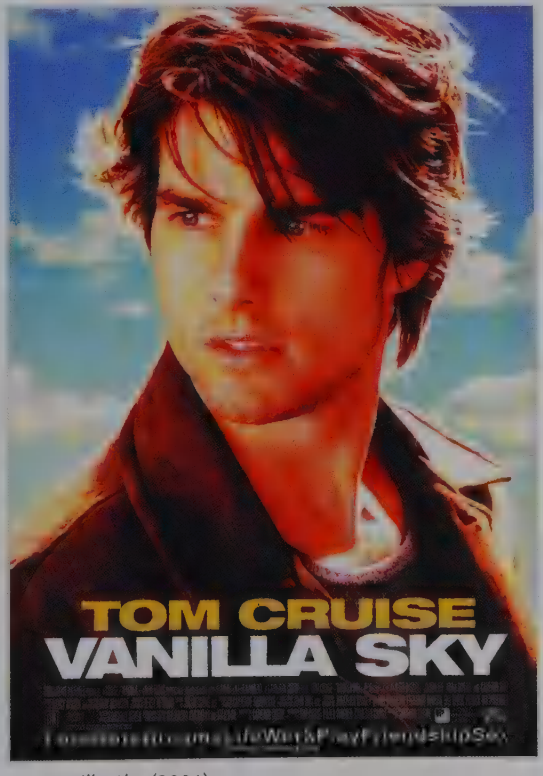
Tag line short, catchy statement on a film poster suggesting the film's content



12 *Pirates of the Caribbean: The Curse of the Black Pearl* (2003)



13 *Titanic* (1997)



14 *Vanilla Sky* (2001)



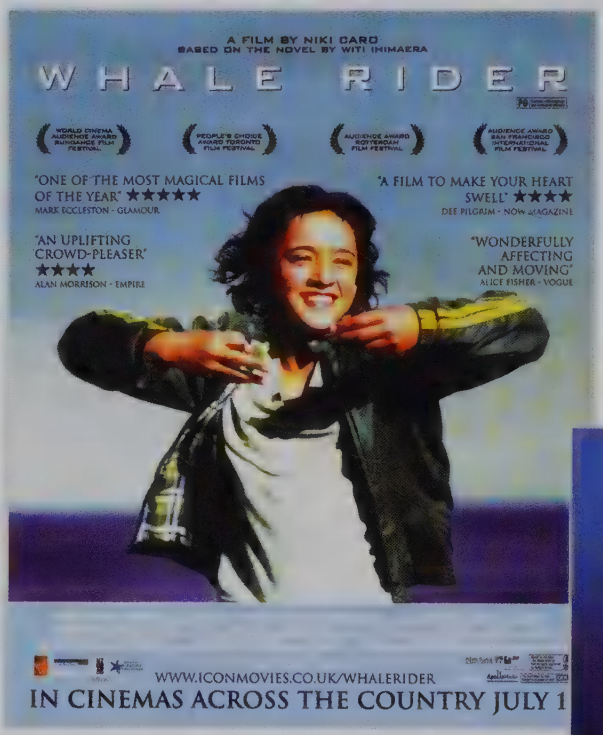
15 *The Hours* (2002)

How could you tell who carried each film? The size and position of the star's name and image are so important that they are part of the star's contract for the film. Big stars try to get their name on the left of the poster and their picture on the right, because these are the most eye-catching positions. Who has these positions in **12**?

Posters are used to publicise and promote a film when it comes out in the cinema. They may be used again when it is available to rent or, a couple of months later, buy on video or DVD.

Film posters: targeting audiences

Film posters target audiences, and audiences in different parts of the world like different sorts of films. They may be particularly interested in a film set in their own country, and people of different cultures may find different types of films, or different features of the same film, appealing. Although the film remains the same, posters may portray it quite differently in different countries.



16 *Whale Rider* poster shown in the UK



17 *Whale Rider* poster shown in the United States

KEY TERM

Title sequence a series of shots and music or graphics that appear at the start of a programme

The answer, of course, is that they are all important at different times and in different ways. Ultimately, it is the performance in front of the camera which attracts and keeps audiences, but for those performances to be outstanding, the team behind the camera need to have done their specialist jobs first.

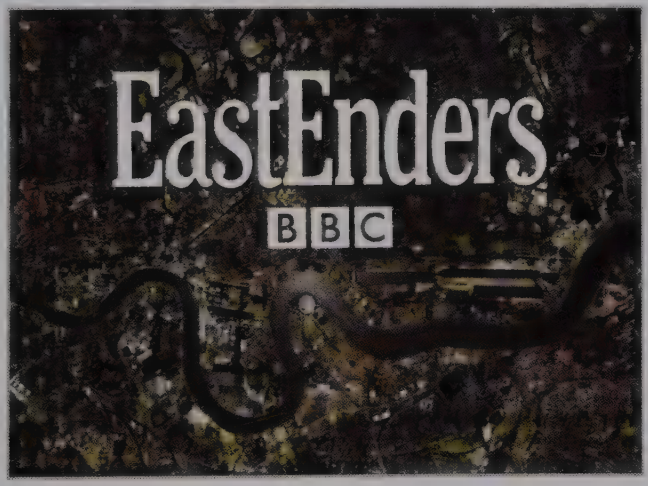
A television production is a complex task, and planning is absolutely vital. However, some things are unpredictable, no matter how good the plan.

- Multiple takes are often needed to 'get it right' in front of the camera – look at programmes which are about moments when actors do not get it right.
- Live audiences: unpredictability on the part of guests and audiences and having to manage large numbers.
- The weather: some programmes have to be cancelled due to poor weather conditions, while others have to be suspended until weather conditions are right – it is not always possible to create a sunny day.
- Illness or scandal: a key character or presenter may be too ill to appear or involved in some public scandal.
- Special effects and stunts do not always go to plan.

Skill and teamwork are needed to get over these problems as they arise. Summer scenes for the *X-Files* were filmed in snowy Vancouver by blowing the snow off the grass first.

Title sequences

The language of the moving image text is a complex mixture of codes and messages that audiences are expert at reading and understanding. A great way to find out about the ways moving image texts communicate with audiences is by examining **title sequences**, which are highly crafted short texts.





Images from the title sequence *of EastEnders*

Look at the shots in **3** from the title sequence of *EastEnders*. What clues do they give you about the programme? You can see some ideas in the table on the next page – can you add any to the list?

What you can see	What you can work out about the programme
The River Thames	It is set in London.
The Millennium Dome at Greenwich	It is set in the present, probably near Limehouse Reach.
The title is in big, bold writing.	It is called EastEnders.
The second image is in more close-up than the first.	The programme will focus on a small part of London.

If you are able to watch the opening, you will be able to pick out many more points. For example:

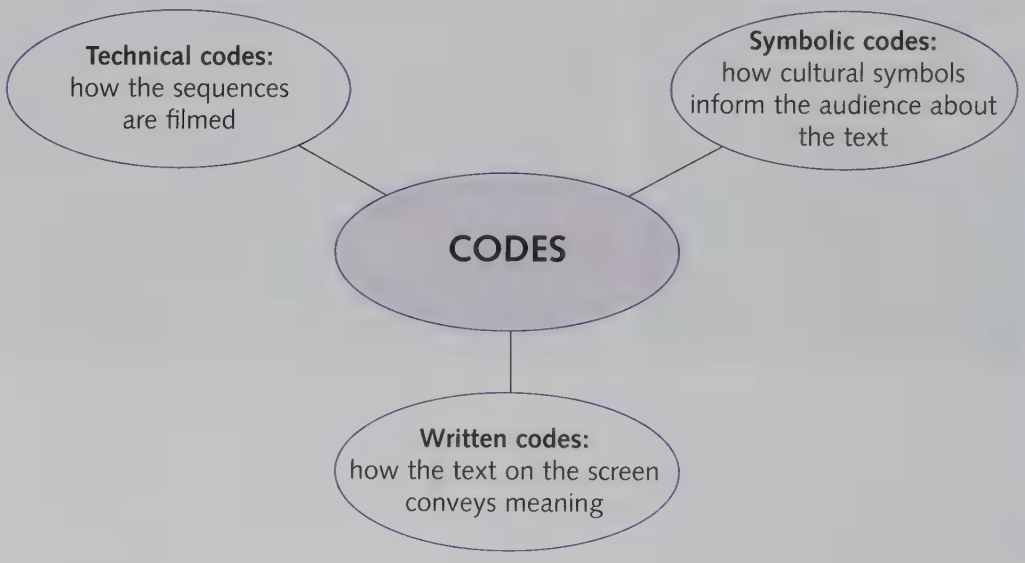
- The camera looks down on the map and rotates just before the title comes up, giving the viewer a different view of the river and its surroundings.
- The title emerges from the map just as the private lives of the characters emerge from their East End homes in the storylines for the programme.

ACTIVITY 2

Watch the title sequence of *Coronation Street*. Pick out the features that give you clues about the programme and put them in a table like the one for *EastEnders*.

Did the *EastEnders* title sequence tell you anything about the characters in the series? You may be surprised that no characters appear, but producers of title sequences often avoid showing people because then the sequence has to be changed much more often as characters join and leave the cast. The title sequence of *Neighbours*, for example, includes characters and has to be changed regularly. Look back at **3**: why do you think that the *EastEnders* sequence had to be changed in about 2000?

One way to approach the analysis of texts such as title sequences is to break down the task into three distinct areas, each of which focuses on a different type of code (see the diagram in **4**).



Types of codes

TIP

Spider diagrams are a quick and clear way to show the examiner what you know.

KEY TERMS

Dissolve when one screen image fades into another

Fade when the screen image gradually disappears

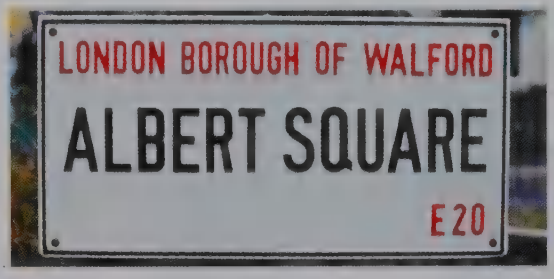
Transition moving from one screen image to another

Wipe when one screen image appears to wipe away another

Technical codes

Technical codes include any of the technical processes used to create the text. Features to look for include:

- *Types of shot*, e.g. establishing shots. These may be of famous landmarks, such as the Millennium Dome, that indicate where events take place, or of signs to show where they are (see **5**) or what their function is, e.g. a sign saying Grange Hill School.



5 This establishing shot shows the location of *EastEnders*

- The **transitions** between shots, such as **fades**, **wipes**, **dissolves** and others.
- The *angle of the shot:* low angles make the subject seem larger and more imposing; high angles have the reverse effect.
- *Camera movements* such as *zooming in* on a subject or *tracking shots*, where the camera follows alongside the subject. This type of shot gets its name from the tracks that are put down so that the camera moves smoothly (**6**).



6 A camera recording a tracking shot

Symbolic codes

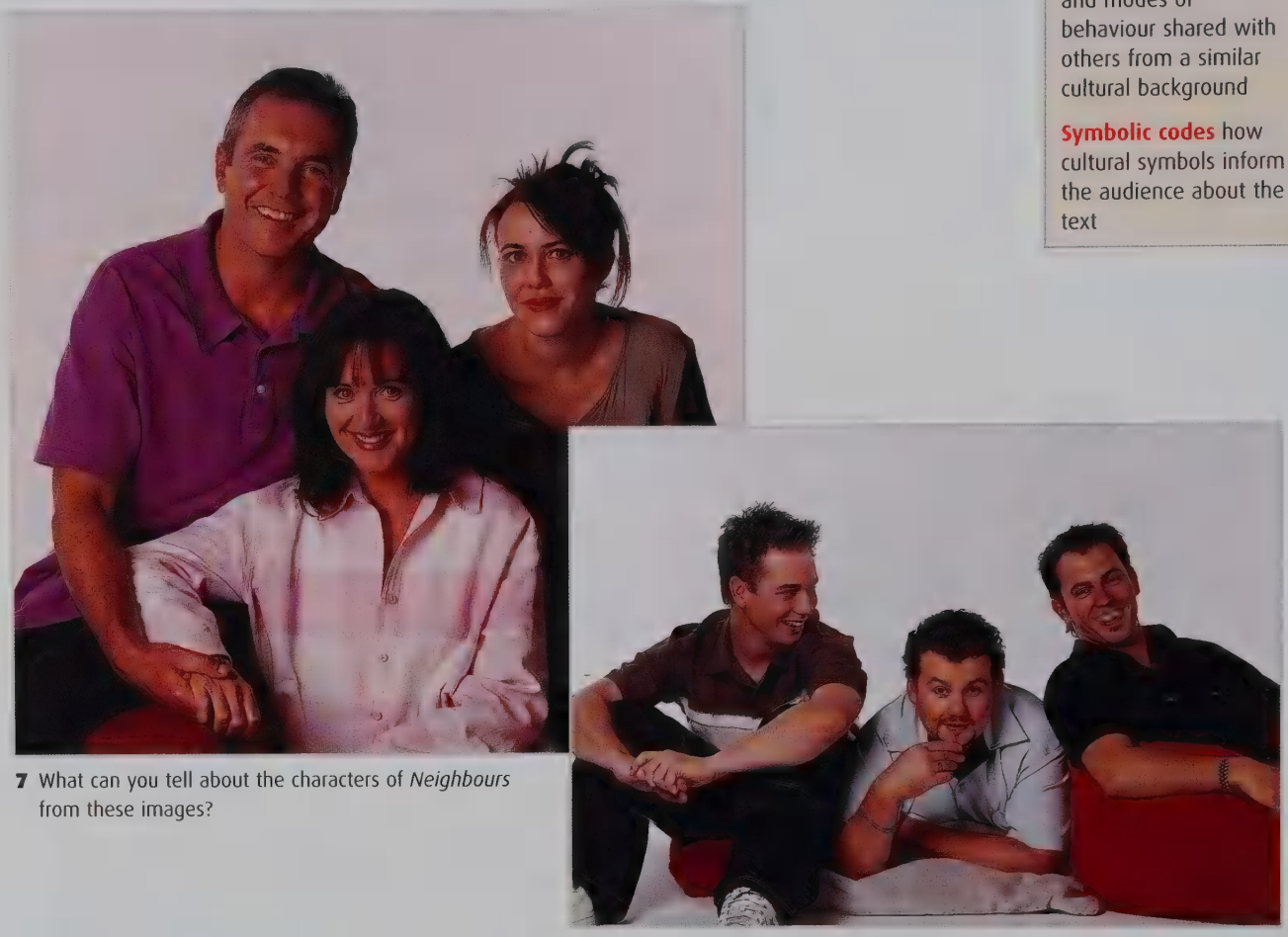
Objects, settings, body language, clothing, colour and soundtrack – the **mise-en-scene** of the sequence – use **symbolic codes** to inform the viewer. As you examine the text, you read the meaning of what you see and hear. People's cultural backgrounds will be important in the way they read an image. Facial expressions and body language are read according to the ways people's backgrounds have led them to interpret them. A polite hand gesture in some cultures may give offence in others. It all depends on a person's **situated culture**.

KEY TERMS

Mise-en-scene settings, costumes, body language, etc. used within the scene to convey the message to the audience

Situated culture the everyday surroundings and modes of behaviour shared with others from a similar cultural background

Symbolic codes how cultural symbols inform the audience about the text



7 What can you tell about the characters of *Neighbours* from these images?

ACTIVITY 3

Watch the title sequence of *Neighbours*.

1 Answer these questions using only what you can see.
   - Where do the characters live?
   - What is each of the characters telling us from their expressions and gestures?

2 Imagine you have been asked to introduce a new character into the programme, such as an elderly aunt who nags everyone. In groups, try different poses and facial expressions to suggest the sort of character you want. Act these out for the rest of the group as a 'freeze-frames' or tableaus where you adopt the pose and stay perfectly still to show what the still picture will look like. Discuss which was the most effective and appropriate for the programme.

If you watch the title sequence you will also hear the **signature tune.** This soon becomes recognisable to the audience and is seen as belonging to it like its 'signature'. Signature tunes signal themes in different ways.

- Some signature tunes communicate meaning through the style, mood and tone.
- Sometimes a particular instrument will be used to signal the setting. In *Coronation Street* the trumpet suggests brass band music associated with working-class northern England – the setting for the programme.
- Some signature tunes have song lyrics which prepare the audience for the programme by introducing themes that will be explored.

ACTIVITY 4

1 Think about the signature tune for *Neighbours*. What do the lyrics tell you about the story?

2 Choose one other signature tune with lyrics. How do the music and the words signal the themes of the programme?

Written codes

The writing on the screen may seem less important than the pictures and the music, but the font style and size, together with the position and movement of the text, can contribute to the ways the audience read the meaning. Look at the style of font used for the hit show *Buffy the Vampire Slayer* in **8**.



This lettering helps to convey meaning

Suggest two reasons why the title has been designed in this way. How does it signal the **genre** of the programme? Why has this particular font been chosen?

Does the font style make a difference to the way the text is read?

KEY TERMS

Genre a type or category of media text, such as a documentary, with certain predictable characteristics

Signature tune the soundtrack played over the images in the title sequence of the programme

ACTIVITY 5

Choose the best font from the box below for a title for each of these genres:

- Horror
- Romantic comedy
- Science fiction
- Game show
- Crime fiction

In each case the show is called *Last Chance*.

ALGERIAN	Fashion	MATISSE
Bauhaus	**Goudy heavyface**	**Matura Script Capitals**
Blackadder	Jokerman	Old English Text
Broadway	*Lucida Handwriting*	**Playbill**
Chiller	Rendo	**Serpentine**

If you prefer, find suitable fonts on a computer or design your own.

Case study: the title sequences to *Star Trek*



Star Trek was hugely popular in the 1960s

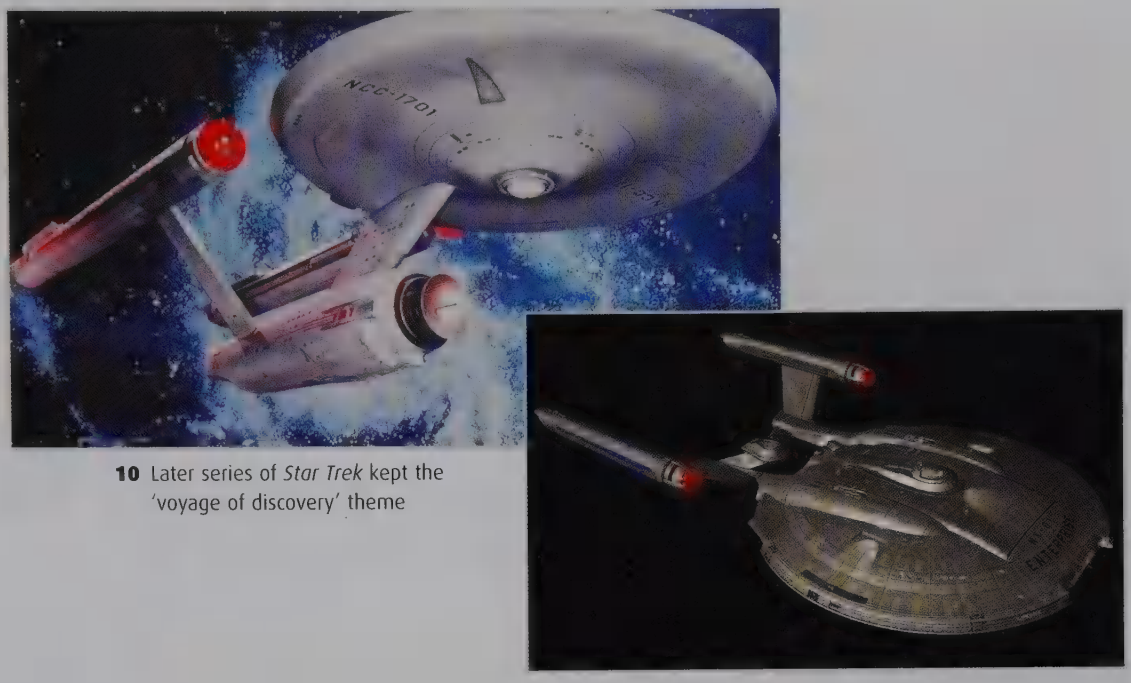
Sometimes the title sequence of a programme can become famous in its own right. In the 1960s the USA and Soviet Union were competing to put a man on the moon. *Star Trek* was first made in 1964 to exploit the interest in space travel this caused.

A voice-over was used in the title sequence to give the audience background information about the story. It explained that the crew of the star ship *Enterprise* were on a five-year mission to explore space – to 'seek out new life and new civilisations …' and 'boldly go where no man has gone before'. This phrase has become almost as famous as the series itself. Meanwhile the visual sequence showed the starship leaving the solar system and moving out into space.

Sequels used a similar title sequence, but changed 'no man' to 'no one'– what reason can you suggest for the change?

TIP

Writing about the hstorical events that influence the programme-makers shows the examiner that you understand its context.



10 Later series of *Star Trek* kept the 'voyage of discovery' theme

KEY TERMS

Prequel programme or series set in a time period before the first series, e.g. *Superman – the Early Years* or *Star Wars: Episode 1 The Phantom Menace*

Sequel continuation of a story, usually with the same characters or settings and themes

Star Trek – the prequel

There have been many more *Star Trek* sequels, but when the title sequence to the **prequel** *Enterprise* (2001) was being designed new ideas were needed to give the show a different feel.

Enterprise is set 150 years after the present and 105 years before the original series. The early version of the starship *Enterprise* travels mainly in the solar system and is technologically behind the original and its sequels.

The title sequence abandons the usual style and instead shows a historical summary of human achievement in travel and discovery and human aspiration to travel in space. The ships shown in the sequence are all called *Enterprise* but they are not all starships.

The fictitious starships include the first warp ship, the *Phoenix*, as seen in the feature film *Star Trek: First Contact* (1996), and finally, the 'new' *Enterprise NX-01* that features in the series. Try to watch the sequence. At what point does the title sequence change from historical accuracy to fictitious events based on the *Star Trek* stories?

TIP

You can find the lyrics of *Faith of the Heart* by following the links on Heinemann Hotlinks.

As well as changes to the overall visual style of the title sequence, *Enterprise* has a very different signature tune. Instead of the instrumental cue of the other series it has a contemporary soft-rock song called *Faith of the Heart*, performed by English opera tenor Russell Watson. The melody and the lyrics work alongside the pictures to suggest the past, present and future as well as the mission of Enterprise (both the series and the ship).

Media texts offer the audience a view of the world and sometimes invite them to make a judgement about events. How does the title sequence of *Enterprise* represent mankind's experience in terms of travel and discovery?

ACTIVITY 10

Look at the title sequences of the original *Star Trek* series, its sequels and prequels. How is human progress represented?

ACTIVITY 11 EXTENSION

1 Watch a variety of title sequences. Comment on how meaning is conveyed through visual images and soundtrack. Consider:
   - how location and time are established
   - how groups of people are represented, if at all
   - how the soundtrack gives clues about the content of the programme
   - how any lettering used relates to the rest of the sequence.

2 **Storyboard** a title sequence of your own to launch a new programme (see pages 172–173 in Unit 9 if you need help). Think about all the features you looked out for in the sequences you watched.

TIP

Put your storyboard from Activity 11 into a folder. This could be included in your final coursework folder as planning or pre-production work.

Television genres



In media terms, a genre is any type of text – programme, film, popular music, etc. – that can be identified or recognised by typical conventions or characteristics (see pages 13–14).

ACTIVITY 12

1 Look in the daily TV schedule in a newspaper. List all the genres that you can find, such as situation comedy and news.

2 In small groups, think of a new TV programme aimed at teenagers. Write down what genre the programme belongs to and when it will be shown. Add any other important details, such as what will happen and who will feature in it.

3 Present your ideas to the rest of the class, and hear the ideas of other groups.

4 Think about all the ideas put forward. What were the most noticeable similarities and differences? Were there any particularly popular genres of programmes? Why might that be?

You will probably notice that some television genres are more popular than others, and that these are often scheduled during peak time. TV programmes are produced by teams of people who conduct extensive **market research** in order to find out what different audiences want to see on television. They are aware that audiences use the media to satisfy certain needs or requirements. Blumler and Katz discussed such audience demand in 1974 in their theory of Uses and Gratifications (see page 88). In summary, they suggested that audiences need to:

- be INFORMED and EDUCATED about the world
- IDENTIFY with characters and situations
- be ENTERTAINED
- use the media as a talking point for SOCIAL INTERACTION
- ESCAPE from their daily lives.

KEY TERMS

Market research finding out what audiences like or dislike about aspects of the media through interviews, surveys and focus groups

Storyboard key moments of a story shown using images and notes – see the example on page 107

Sub-genre genres can be divided up further into sub-genres, e.g. teen comedies are a sub-genre of comedy

ACTIVITY 13

Look again at the television programmes and genres you identified in the daily schedules. Apply the Uses and Gratifications theory to them in order to see what audience needs are being satisfied by each genre. Put your answers in a table like the one below by writing ticks in the correct columns.

Programme	Inform	Identify	Entertain	Social interaction	Escape
Wildlife documentary	✓		✓	✓	

Introduction to television drama

Television drama is a hugely popular television genre, attracting wide-ranging audiences simply because there are so many different dramas to choose from in terms of both style and content. Since it is such a large genre, it is useful to divide it up further into **sub-genres** such as medical drama, police drama and docu-drama, in order to look at it more closely



11 David Jason in the Yorkshire Television drama *Micawber* (2002)

ACTIVITY 14

1. Watch the opening sequences of a range of TV dramas. Finish a copy of diagram **12** showing the typical sub-genre conventions or characteristics of each one. One has been done for you already. You may need to add more arms or boxes.
2. What other impressions do you get from the opening sequences? Try to add in more notes on your diagram about any of the following areas: *music*, *striking images*, *on-screen text*.
3. Discuss with a partner what storylines are suggested by the openings. What clues tell you the kinds of stories that will be important in the programmes? Look out for where the camera spends extra time, giving importance to certain moments and particular characters and their stories.

ACTIVITY 15

Play a game with a partner.

1 Each of you should choose two characters from different well known TV drama series.

2 Think of three facts about each character and give them one by one to your partner as clues, starting with the most difficult to guess. Award 5 points for guessing with just one clue, 3 for two guesses and 1 for three guesses. (You could make this a whole-class activity with rounds and a final winner.)

Analysing character can revolve around several important areas:

- The character's role in the drama
- Their relationship with other characters
- The ways that the actor brings the character to life:
  - use of voice or accent
  - movement and gesture
  - emotional power to engage with the audience.





14 Characters in soap operas become very familiar to their audiences

KEY TERMS

Central protagonists key characters around whom the text and narrative are centred

Stereotypical grouping people together according to simple shared characteristics, without allowing for any individual uniqueness

The audience can usually spot two main types of characters in a drama – those who are less important and are there for 'padding', and those around whom the main narrative(s) centre. For example, in a medical drama the people who have accidents are only shown for some of one programme, whereas the hospital staff are seen week after week. The less important characters are less developed and often more **stereotypical** than the main characters or **central protagonists** (**14**).

ACTIVITY 16

Watch a clip from any TV drama. Decide which are the less important characters and which are the central protagonists. What information did you use to help you decide?

Setting

The location of a TV drama is important in establishing a sense of a real place where the story can exist. Many regional features may well appear, such as landmarks and the local accent, dress and customs of those who live there.

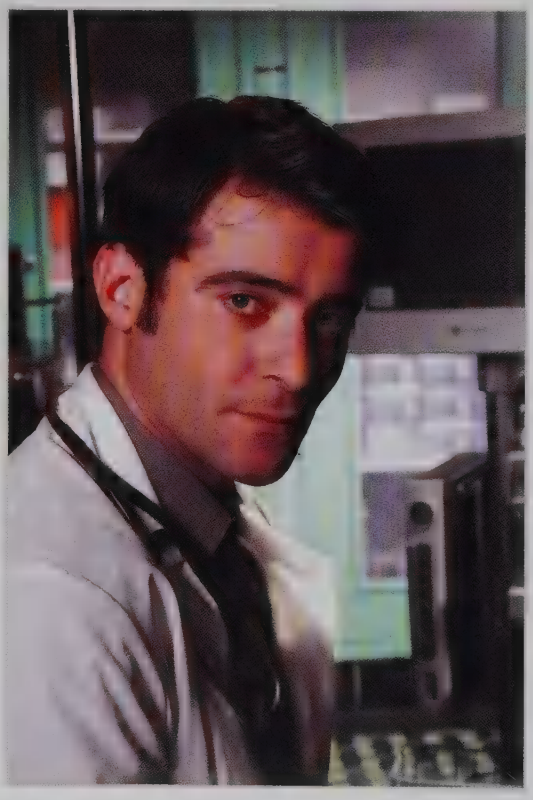
These features are included to encourage as strong a sense of engagement with the world of the drama, the characters and their lives as possible. Audiences continued to remember Dirty Den, for example, long after his exit from Albert Square because he was so perfectly set into the location and community of *EastEnders* – this also explains why his return was so well publicised. Fans of TV drama sometimes write in to their favourite characters, forgetting that they are played by actors and do not really exist.

One of the most important features of most television dramas is that they create believable or realistic worlds that audiences can watch and feel convinced by. The following case study will help you focus on just one sub-genre – the medical drama – in order to see how producers go about creating those real worlds.

Case study – medical drama

Medical drama is one of the most popular sub-genres of drama on television. It has its own set of conventions, all of which are designed to make viewers believe that the world of the programme really exists.

Medical drama developed from soap opera – serialised drama on radio and television paid for by washing powder manufacturers. It became clear that the audience for daytime soap operas – housewives at home during the day – also enjoyed dramas based in hospital wards and in doctors' surgeries. Before long soap operas appeared during peak-time viewing. Early examples included *Doctor Finlay's Casebook* and *Doctor Kildare*, which were extremely popular in the 1960s.



Two of the most popular UK medical dramas of recent years are *Casualty*, which began broadcasting on BBC1 in 1985, and its sister programme *Holby City*, also on BBC1, which began life in 1999. *ER*, on Channel 4, is an American medical drama set in Chicago that also has a large following (see **15**).

15 *ER* is a popular medical drama from the USA

Sometimes the humour is caused by the relationship between the characters – naughty children exasperating fathers or older brothers playing tricks on younger siblings. This comedy arises from the situation people are in, and is therefore called *situation comedy* or *sitcom*.

Humour also reflects people's beliefs and personalities, so they may prefer some programmes to others depending on their own experience.

ACTIVITY 22

Draw a table like the one below. Think of four more examples to add to the list, using your own experience of what you find funny.

Visual comedy	Comedy situations
Dad falls off ladder when son opens upstairs window.	*Naughty son hides school report but 'good' daughter finds it and blackmails him.*

Sitcoms and the family

The sitcom is now a television genre, but it began its life on radio in half-hour shows presenting characters in a common environment such as the workplace or the family home.

Family life has been a subject of sitcom since the early days of television. There have been many types of family represented. In the USA in the 1950s a hit sitcom *I Love Lucy* (**17**) brought to the screens a lovable yet hopeless housewife who was always getting into tricky situations that usually involved misunderstandings with her husband Ricky. The network did something unusual for the times with this live television show – they recorded it. This meant that they could show repeats and attract new audiences as the years went by.



17 Lucy and Ricky from *I Love Lucy*

ACTIVITY 23

1 Read this outline of an original *I Love Lucy* episode. How would Lucy and Ricky look and behave in a new series made for today's audiences? Think about the social changes that have taken place over the past fifty years, especially in the roles of men and women. Suggest ways to bring it up to date and think of comic complications that could happen before all is put right in the end.

Men Are Messy
Tired of cleaning up after Ricky, Lucy divides the apartment into two. He can mess up his half if he wants, but he cannot come into her half.

2 In groups, improvise some of the situations you have thought of. Vote for which you think would work best as an episode of a sitcom.

Although the types of things that go wrong that are the source of humour have not changed over time, other things have. One of the changes in society since the 1950s is that few women now are full-time housewives. Many of the plots of the *I Love Lucy* shows centred on her attempts to gain some independence, suggesting that her husband was very much the boss.

Plots in modern sitcoms still feature the battle of the sexes, but are the women stronger or weaker than the men? Read the article about the British sitcom *My Family* in **18**.



Ben is the harassed centre of the Harper family. His wife Susan is intelligent, sharp, witty and something of a control freak, and their still-loving marriage is a vehicle that may squeak but nonetheless keeps moving along. Ben – though he complains a lot – knows that he has done well in this regard. Susan works as a tour guide, Ben as a dentist, and their home life is complicated by the normal wear and tear of three children. Nick, the eldest, is a lazy, slow-witted incompetent who nonetheless has a certain charm. Janey is a stereotypical teenager, concerned with boys, fashion and looks. Michael is the youngest, a serious, studious boy arguably brighter than his brother and sister. At work, Ben is assisted by his dense hygienist Brigitte (series one) and by son Nick (series two). Janey left to go to university at the start of the third series and returned at Christmas to announce that she was pregnant.

18 *My Family*

TIP

You can find out more about *My Family* by following the links on Heinemann Hotlinks.

KEY TERM

Representation
how the media shape images of people, places and events and present them to the audience

ACTIVITY 24

Discuss these questions with a partner.

1 What do you learn about each family member in the article?
2 Which characters, from their descriptions, do you think have the most power in the Harper household?
3 What kinds of conflicts do you expect between members of the Harper family from what you have learned about their characters?
4 Why do you think sitcom is so often based on family life?

The **representation** of men, women and teenagers in sitcoms is often stereotypical.

- Men are often seen to be weaker than their female counterparts, usually their wives. They may think that they are going to get one over on them, may even look as though they are going to come out on top, but they never win and end up either losing face or losing money.
- The women are often strong characters who keep the whole family on track despite the antics of their hopeless husbands and naughty children.

Do these stereotypes also apply to sitcoms from America? The USA sitcom called *Malcolm in the Middle* also explores what life is like in a family. The narrative style, or the way the story is told, centres on the Malcolm of the title. Read his description of the family as he sees them in **19**.

ACTIVITY 25

1 What similarities are there between the families in *Malcolm in the Middle* and *My Family*?
2 Work together in groups to produce a storyline for Malcolm and his family. Write the first two minutes as a monologue for Malcolm in the style of his journal as below.

My dad's a thinker – none of us knows what about! What my mum says, goes – she's in charge of everything, even the remote control. Francis, my oldest brother, is cool – so he got kicked out. Reese, the next, is dumb, dumb, dumb. And Dewey, the youngest, was only fun until he could talk well enough to tell tales. As for me, Malcolm – well, my skin is clearing up, Reese is in high school so I don't see much of him, and life is getting better – I think!



19 *Malcolm in the Middle*

The strong mother and the exasperated father are represented here in a family situation. The family seem less middle-class than the Harpers, less wealthy and even more dysfunctional, that is, it has difficulty functioning and communicating in emotionally healthy ways.

One of the reasons for the programme's popularity was its ability to present material the audience could identify with. Everyone likes to think their family is perfect, but also knows deep down that it is not, so it is reassuring to see families on television trying to work through problems, as everyone has to do. Could it be that this type of text offers its audience a way of dealing with feelings about their concerns and fears?

Grumpy old men

Another frequent sitcom stereotype is the 'grumpy old man'. Examples from the past include the father in *Steptoe and Son* and Alf Garnett in *Till Death Us Do Part*. More recent texts include *Phoenix Nights*, *Last of the Summer Wine* and US sitcom *Becker*. How many more examples can you think of?

It could be said that in the past comedy was a way for women and children to deal with the authoritarian husband and father figure in many families. The 'grumpy old man' was not only a figure of fun, but often ultimately powerless, as behind his back his seemingly downtrodden wife quietly got her own way. Do modern sitcoms portray this situation in quite the same way? Can you think of any recent sitcoms where the 'grumpy' or 'bossy' role is filled by a woman or a young person? For example, Patty and Selma in *The Simpsons* are both grumpy. What does this say about the changes in family structure?



20 Grumpiest of them all? Victor Meldrew from *One Foot in the Grave*

ACTIVITY 26 EXTENSION

In groups, research the use of the stereotype of the grumpy old man in TV sitcom in the past 30 years. Your research resources could include the Internet, TV listings, books and interviews with older relatives about their favourite grumpy characters. Present your ideas visually and in writing for a wall display.

Newspaper language



The 'language' of newspapers is not just the words that appear in them. As with other media languages, it includes the pictures that are used, different **font** styles and sizes in text and headings and the way these things are put together in the layout of the page.

No aspect of the way newspapers are put together is an accident. At every stage of production people are making decisions which affect the way the paper looks, reads ... and sells!

The copy

Copy is written by journalists called reporters. Writing for newspapers is very different from the sort of writing done by, say, a novelist. News reporters need to get across the maximum amount of information in the shortest possible time. They also aim to get the 'bare bones' of the story established in the first sentence or two – if you are hooked into the story from the very start you will carry on reading.

Journalists are taught to KISS – Keep It Short and Simple. They used also to be taught to get the 'Five Ws' – Who? What? Where? When? Why? – into the first sentences of their story. Now styles of writing for newspapers have moved on. Trying to pack in all five Ws made for indigestible sentences and this rule is not always followed to the letter – but as a guideline it still offers a helpful starting point.

ACTIVITY 4

1 Look at the opening two sentences from the main front page story in three different newspapers: two tabloids and one broadsheet. How many of the Five Ws has the reporter managed to get in for each story?

2 Now do the same for three stories from inside the papers.

The pictures

The first newspapers printed three hundred years ago had very few pictures – and those pictures were drawings because, of course, the camera had not been invented. Nowadays news photographs play a very important part in the whole look of a newspaper, especially the front page.

Look in **7** and **8** at how two newspapers set out their front pages reporting on two of the biggest international news stories of the past 100 years.

Both events were highly significant in the Western world. Almost anyone who was alive at the time remembers exactly what they were doing when they first heard the news of President Kennedy's assassination or the terrorist attack on New York's twin towers. Nearly 40 years separates these two front pages, and the style of newspaper layout changed dramatically between the two events.

ACTIVITY 5

Look carefully at front pages **7** and **8**, paying special attention to the photographs.

1 Why do you think the **picture editors** chose these particular images? What does each tell us about the story?

2 What do you think they wanted the reader to feel about each event? What is it about the way the pictures have been presented that helps to influence how the reader feels?

KEY TERMS

Anchor pin down a particular meaning of a drawing or photograph

Angle the particular point of view a newspaper wants its readers to take on a story

Caption words underneath a picture

Copy printed articles that appear in newspapers

Font the different styles of lettering used in printing papers

Picture editor person responsible for choosing the photographs that go into a newspaper


DAILY EXPRESS

KENNEDY ASSASSINATED

A sniper's bullet

Seconds before: His smile for the crowds

ARRESTED

Lyndon sworn in

Policeman shot

Straight to hospital

7 Front page of the *Daily Express*, 21 November 1963


THE TIMES

When war came to America

Times reporter James Bone was looking up at the World Trade Centre minutes before the twin towers fell from the sky

8 Front page of *The Times*, 12 September 2001

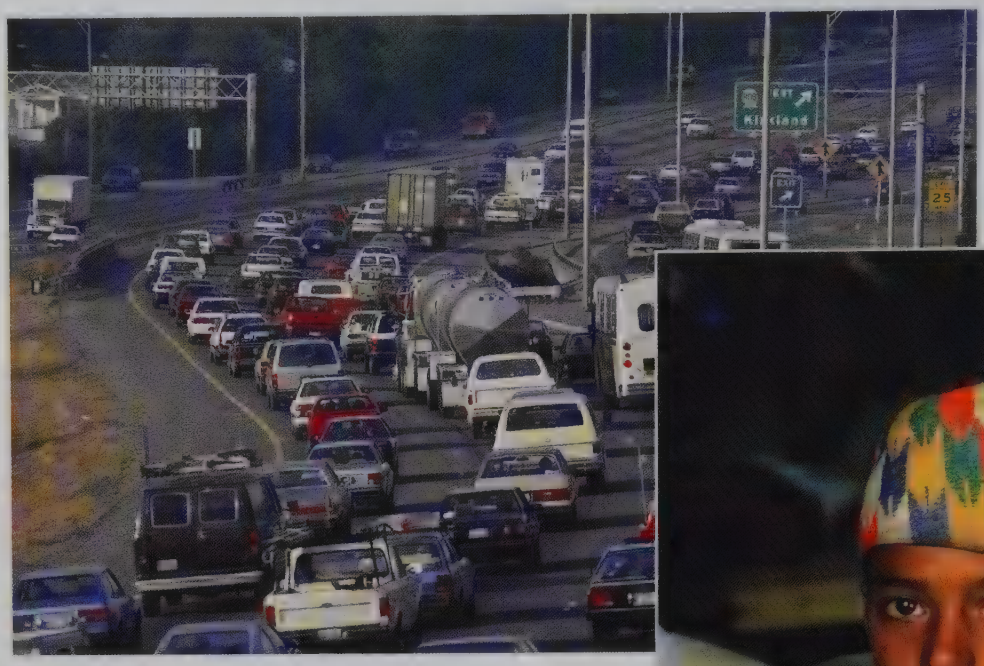
Captions

People say that 'a picture is worth a thousand words'. Certainly the photograph of New York after the attack on the twin towers in **8** says a great deal about the event. The caption that goes with a photograph is also very important because it can **anchor** a meaning – it tries to push the reader towards one **angle** by providing an interpretation for them. Look at photograph **9**. There could be a number of interpretations made of this image. However, choosing suitable captions could alter the way people read it.

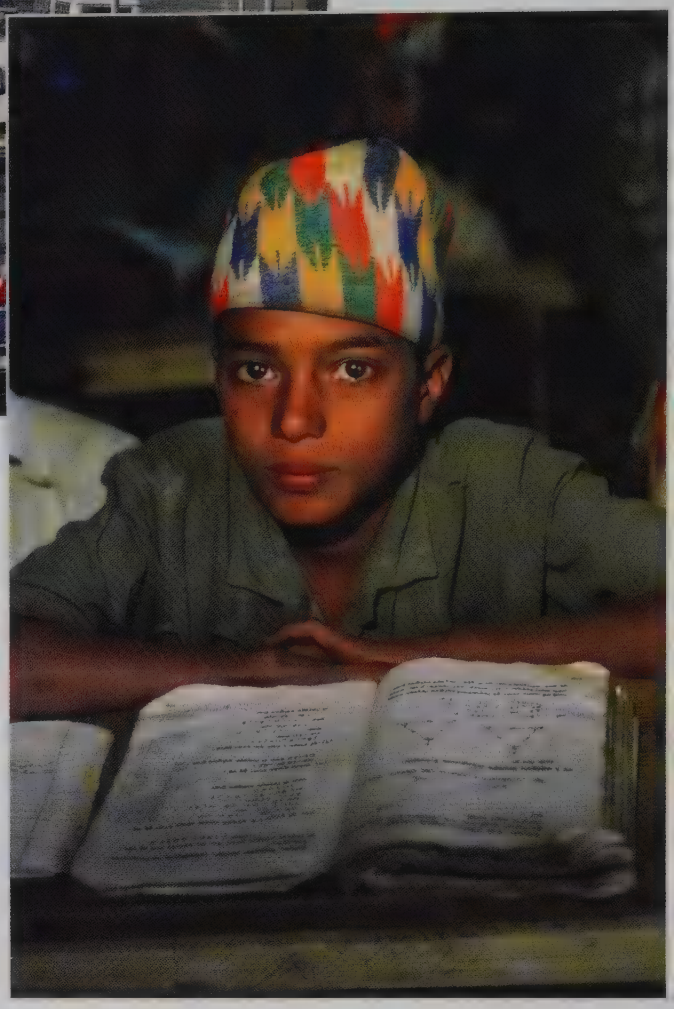
- *South Africa's government has managed to re-house many of its people from tin shacks into solid, brick-built houses:* this caption gives a positive slant on the picture.
- *Unemployment still blights South Africa's townships:* this caption gives a very different, more negative meaning.



9 Street scene in Khayelitsha, South Africa



10



11

ACTIVITY 6

1 Look at photographs **10** and **11**. Write two possible captions to appear in a newspaper for each photograph. One caption should give a positive angle and the other a more negative angle.

2 Compare your captions with those of a partner. What elements of the photographs have each of you chosen to focus attention on in your various captions?

ACTIVITY 7 EXTENSION

In pairs or groups, take a series of photographs around the school site. Make a wall display featuring these photographs, giving captions which alter the way a viewer might interpret them.

Where do newspapers get their photographs? There are three main sources:

- A photographer specifically sent to the scene of the story to cover the story will send back the best possible shots under the circumstances.
- Photos can be set up after the event where there is much more chance to pose the subjects and get a good composition.
- Photos not originally taken as news pictures are used because they are the only available images, for example school photographs of a missing child or images taken from security cameras.

Headlines

Good headlines are crucial, especially on the front page – this headline will draw a purchaser's attention to the paper when it is on the shelf among its competitors. Broadsheet editors will try to draw readers to their stories by using concise headlines which sometimes also give the newspaper's angle on the story, but tabloid headlines are large and catchy.

The Sun has become famous for its controversial headlines. Although these can be amusing, they sometimes cross the line from humour into bad taste. In 1989 the paper printed the headline THE TRUTH above an article about the Hillsborough football disaster in which 95 Liverpool fans were killed. *The Sun*'s 'truth' was that the disaster was caused by drunk Liverpool fans behaving badly. Sales of the paper in Liverpool collapsed, with many newsagents refusing to stock it, and have never recovered.

Techniques	Examples
Abbreviating names	David Beckham is usually 'Becks'.
Parody: taking a well known saying and giving it a slight twist	BRAWL OVER BAR THE SHOUTING
Incorrect or invented spelling	SVENTASTIC for football manager Sven-Goran Eriksson
Alliteration	BILL BOUNCES BACK
Pun: a play on words, often giving a double meaning	BOOTIFUL – winning goal in Cup Final
Rhyming	RIO GIVES HEAVE-HO TO THE MUMBO JUMBO

12 Tricks of the headline-writer's trade

ACTIVITY 8

1 In chart **12** you can see some techniques that headline writers use to draw readers in. Look through a copy of one of the tabloids. Try to find examples of headlines using any of these techniques.

2 Take any story from the same paper and try to make up your own headline using a different technique to the one already used by the paper.



13 The features of newspaper layout

Layout

When all the copy is written and all the photographs have been chosen, the final choices concern how the page is to be laid out. Layout is a key part of the battle to grab the reader's attention and hang on to it.

The **sub-editors** of the paper use computer technology to set out the pages. They work from a page grid that breaks the page into a series of columns. In the past pages were almost always set out in columns, with nothing breaking the grid pattern. Modern page design very often allows both photographs and text to spill outside rigid columns to create dramatic visual impact.

TIP

Knowing the terms to describe newspaper layout will help you to know what to look for when writing about them, and increase your marks.

In **13** a front page from *The Mirror* has been marked up with the terms used by sub-editors to describe modern newspaper layout.

Newspapers are constantly researching the ways in which people read pages. They have found, for example, that:

- headlines near photographs are read more than those placed further away
- using colour does not make a story more likely to be read
- people reading a paper look at most of the photographs, artwork and headlines – but much less of the copy.

Above all, a newspaper wants to achieve an individual visual style. This is about individual preferences. What people in Britain regard as good page design may not be what people in other countries like.

ACTIVITY 9

Look at the two European front pages in **14** and **15**.

1 Make some notes on the differences you notice between them, using the terms shown in **13**. You could use a chart like the one below.

Le Télégramme	Neue Zürcher Zeitung
Large main photo	*Small photo*

2 Now note down the differences you can find between each of these front pages and the British front page design in **13**.

KEY TERM

Sub-editor person responsible for the layout of a newspaper



Votre jardin. Les tendances du fleurissement estival. Page 49

0.75 €

Le Télégramme

CHATEAULIN

N° 17.977 VENDREDI 11 AVRIL 2003

BRETAGNE
TITRE DE REINE : UN TRÉSOR À PROTÉGER

SÉCURITÉ ROUTIÈRE : 100 € LA BANANE !

PNEUMOPATHIE : TRANSFERT D'UN BRESTOIS À RENNES

FRANCE
CONCORDE : FIN D'UNE LÉGENDE

SPORTS
2007 : LA COUPE DU MONDE EN FRANCE

L'IRAK FACE À SON DESTIN

Protectorat américain ? Administration sous le contrôle de l'ONU ? transition ? Alors que les combats se poursuivent, les Irakiens Pour l'heure, face à cet avenir incertain, les scènes de pillages et de Une situation anarchique à laquelle il est urgent de mettre fin.

E.LECLERC
QUIMPER
Préparez Pâques !
LANGUE DE BŒUF FRAÎCHE ORIGINE CEE
PINTADE FERMIÈRE LABEL ROUGE ORIGINE SUD-OUEST
QUEUES DE L

14 The front page from French newspaper *La Télégramme*, 11 April 2003



Freitag, 5. Februar 1999 · Nr. 29

Der Zürcher Zeitung 220. Jahrgang

Neue Zürcher Zeitung

INTERNATIONALE AUSGABE

Heute mit: «Spektrum Deutschland»

Ausdehnung der Heroinversuche in Holland

HEUTE IN DER NZZ

INTERNATIONAL

Amnesty untersucht Gewalt in Nordirland

Die USA zum Eingreifen in Kosovo bereit

Kanzlerabstimmung in Rio de Janeiro

WIRTSCHAFT

Die «braune» Zeit der Deutschen Bank

SCHWEIZ

Krankenversicherungsgesetz unter der Lupe

Neutralität ist nicht Passivität

Kontroverse um Paul Grüninger

ZÜRICH

Neuregelung der Spitzenmedizin

FEUILLETON

Valerio Olgiatis Schulhaus in Paspels

SPORT

Gründung einer Anti-Doping-Agentur

VERMISCHTE MELDUNGEN

Kampagne gegen den Abergläuben in China

BEILAGE

Medien und Informatik

Inhaltsübersicht

Kämpfer der Befreiungsarmee Kosovo im Dorf Dragobilje (Bild ap)

Grünes Licht für Kosovo-Verhandlungen

Teilnahme von serbischen und albanischen Delegationen

Erneut Verurteilung eines chinesischen Dissidenten

Die jüngste Repressionswelle erfasst auch unautorisierte Arbeiterproteste

Der jordanische König in kritischem Zustand

Starker Druck auf Belgrad

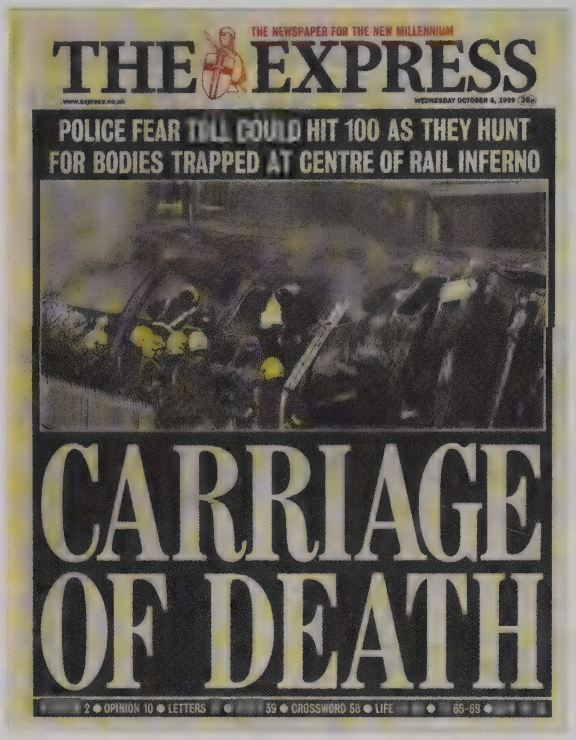
Neue Zeile der Demokratischen Partei

Demonstration bei Hamburg gegen den Atomausstieg

15 This newspaper was published in Germany on 5 February 1999

Fact?

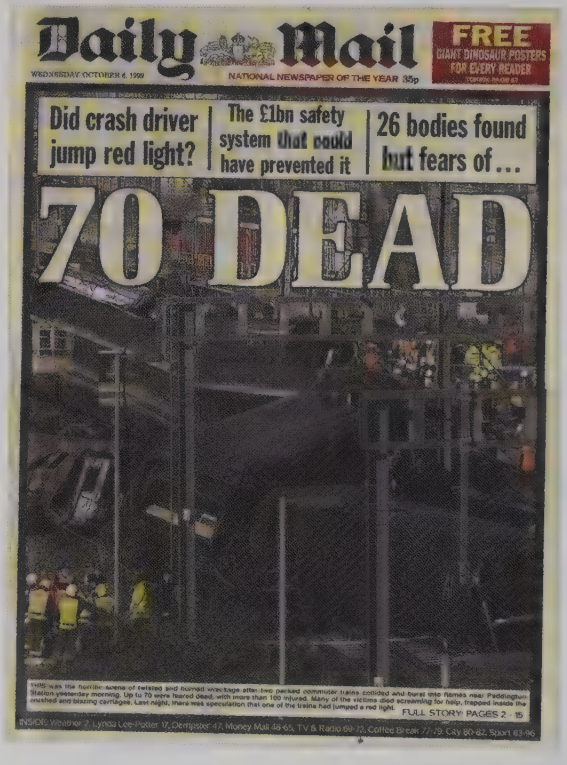
John Walter seemed to think that newspapers should mainly report facts. The three front pages shown in images **16** to **18** appeared on the day after the Paddington rail disaster in 1999. They show that sometimes the facts can be a bit different, depending on which paper you are reading them in.



16 Front page of the *Daily Express*, 6 October 1999



18 Front page of *The Mirror*, 6 October 1999



17 Front page of the *Daily Mail*, 6 October 1999

KEY TERMS

Leader article where the paper's editor or owner says what they think about a particular issue

News sources the various places where journalists get their stories

Positive representation presenting a favourable view of individuals, groups or ideas

Press release information provided to newspapers by a variety of organisations (government departments, charities, pressure groups, etc.)

ACTIVITY 11

Discuss in pairs *why* you think each newspaper chose the front page it did.

1 Why did *The Daily Express* use a higher number? Why did the splash head then choose a different emphasis?

2 Why did the other two papers present the number of dead as a fact?

Opinion

It is often not the facts that are given but the opinions of the reporters, editors or their sources that introduce an angle. Sometimes the papers make it obvious that they are expressing an opinion. **Leader articles** on the Editorial page set out what the paper's editor or owner thinks should be done about a particular issue. These usually discuss serious topics – whether Britain should join the Euro or whether it should go to war, for example.

But often the way news events are reported builds a certain point of view into the story. In this case the angle is governed by the choices editorial staff make – the paper chooses the viewpoint it wants to put across to its readers.

News is often reported in terms of *heroes* and *villains*. Sometimes it is easy. Saddam Hussein was rarely represented as anything other than an out-and-out villain who had killed thousands of his own people and spent Iraq's oil wealth on himself. However, sports personalities and teams often swing quickly from being heroes to villains and back again within a matter of days. News reports always try to tell a story.

ACTIVITY 12

Using a copy of any national daily newspaper, find three stories that present the reader with clear heroes and villains.

1 Which words from the articles make you think that one person is the 'goody' and the other is the 'baddy'?

2 Are any pictures used to support the view you are given of the characters in the piece?

News sources

It is important to know about **news sources** because how newspapers represent the news of the day is affected by the sources from which that news comes.

Over 60 per cent of all newspaper stories come from **press releases** or press conferences. A busy local paper will often print a well written press release, following the Five Ws and KISS rules, almost as it stands. If you want your school play to be given a good press, you need a good press release, describing your 'gripping' performance of a 'much loved classic' play. In Media Studies terms, you will have achieved a **positive representation** of the production.

ACTIVITY 13

Write a press release for an event in your area. This could be a sports event, a live music concert, a non-uniform day – anything you think your local paper ought to cover. Remember the Five Ws and KISS!

Generally speaking, local newspapers get their news from:

- Agendas for meetings, e.g. the County Council, the local Health Authority Trust, the Steam Railway Preservation Society
- Press releases sent by email and post from various organisations
- Police or Fire and Rescue services
- News Agencies such as the Press Association and Reuters
- Members of the public telling the paper of incidents or events
- Contacts: people the paper's journalists call regularly to see if they have a story; occasionally these people will call the paper to tip them off about an event.

This list might lead you to think that journalists could go to many different places to **source** their news. However, research has shown that they use a remarkably limited range. If the sources are limited then so will be the view of the world the papers give us.

Journalists put sources into the following three categories:

Primary sources: the courts, police, fire service, Members of Parliament, organisations representing business and industry, trade unions, football clubs

Secondary sources: schools, churches, charities, representatives of pressure groups such as Friends of the Earth

Alternative sources: representatives of religions other than Christianity, ethnic minority groups, feminist, lesbian and gay groups, anti-war groups such as CND, representatives of political parties other than the main three.

Critics say that the routines used by journalists for sourcing news mean that their stories reflect the distribution of power in the country. People from the leading groups and institutions have easier access to the press and so their views are heard more often. Representatives from 'alternative' groups get little or no press coverage and this reinforces their powerlessness in society.

ACTIVITY 14

1 Examine any national or local newspaper. Choose three news stories. Try to work out which news sources might have provided each story. Use this list to help you:
   - A press conference given by an organisation
   - A press release from an organisation
   - Parliament
   - The emergency services
   - Member of the public directly contacting the paper
   - A detailed investigation by one of the paper's reporters.

2 Choose one of the three stories that seems to have a clear angle on the events it describes. What would the alternative viewpoint be on this story? Where might the journalist have had to go to get an alternative angle?

KEY TERM

Source find information to use when writing news stories

News values

Most journalists will tell you that selecting the right stories for the day is a matter of experience and instinct. But in a famous study in 1973 Galtang and Ruge found that these factors help a story to get into the news:

- *Timescale:* a murder is committed and discovered quickly, so it fits the timescale on which newspapers work. An increase in gun crime, which happens over a long period, will only get reported when there are a series of gun-related crimes.
- *The size of an event:* A rail crash killing 25 people is big news; a train derailment with no injuries is not.
- *How clear the event is:* News need not be simple, but a very complicated story will probably get left out.
- *Predictability:* If the press expects something to happen then it will. A big anti-capitalist demonstration planned for central London will get reported, even if it passes off peacefully, because the press expect violence and send journalists to cover it.
- *Continuity:* A running story, like a war, will continue to be covered.
- *Reference to elite people or nations:* News about the USA or their president is more likely to get covered than similar news from Costa Rica.

News coverage is often **ethnocentric**. How do newspapers, and other media, report on less developed countries? These nations appear in the news when there are famines, natural disasters, violent revolutions or political corruption. Readers are invited to be thankful that they live in a stable country, where everyone has the basics of life and is fairly and honestly governed. But can it *really* be true that nothing good ever happens in the developing world?

Newspapers are said to give a 'window on the world', but in reality they give the view from a window facing in only one direction. Behind the other three walls there are all sorts of things going on, but they do not get reported.

ACTIVITY 15

1 Conduct your own survey into the news values of one tabloid daily paper for a week. Without reading them in full, complete a tally chart like the one below.
   - Count the total number of news stories each day.
   - Count the number of stories about Africa each day, adding that as a second column to your chart.
   - Of the stories which you found about Africa, make a note of how many were giving good news about the country and how many were reporting problems.

Day	News stories	Stories about Africa	Good news	Bad news
Monday	17	3	1	2

2 At the end of the week, choose the three 'biggest' news stories. Try to work out how many of the points on Galtang and Ruge's list apply to each story.

KEY TERM

Ethnocentric biased towards events in the country in which the paper is produced

Newspaper audiences

Why do newspapers need to know about their audiences?

The running costs of a newspaper have to be covered by:

- money from the sale of newspapers, which depends on the **circulation figure**
- money provided by advertisers taking space in the paper. The bigger the **readership**, the more they can charge people to advertise.

Just like any other media industry, it is very important for newspapers to know how large their readership is and how that readership breaks down in terms of gender and social class.

Advertising has an obvious effect on the way a paper looks. **Display adverts** create visual impact. In fact, when sub-editors lay up a page they put in the advertisements first.

- Some papers try to avoid placing adverts on certain pages, such as the front page.
- Advertisers sometimes pay more to ensure their product is the only one advertised on a page.
- Advertisers try to avoid the sports pages, so the remaining pages may have a high proportion of advertising content.
- It is the adverts, not the news, which determine how many pages an issue has: more adverts, a bigger paper!

How do newspapers find out about their readers?

Both advertisers and newspapers classify their readership into **socio-economic groups**; readers in the A, B and C1 categories will have more money to spend on things they see advertised.

Within those categories, newspapers use information from the National Readership Survey about different genders, particular interest groups – like car drivers or home owners – and age groups. You can see information from the NRS website in **19**. Just to be sure the newspapers are telling them the truth, advertisers can go to the Audit Bureau of Circulation, which checks that circulation figures are correct.

KEY TERMS

Circulation figure number of copies sold of any one newspaper

Display advert advert that takes up quite a lot of the page and often uses a big colour photo

Readership number of people who read a particular newspaper: its 'audience'. This figure is larger than the circulation because one copy can be read by several people.

Socio-economic groups researchers classify people into six categories, A, B, C1, C2, D and E, based mainly on the work they do

TIP

You can find the very latest information about readership by visiting the websites of The National Readership Survey and the Audit Bureau of Circulation via Heinemann Hotlinks.

Daily Newspapers Monday to Saturday Average readership	Adults													
	Total adults		ABC1		C2DE		15–44		45+		Men		Women	
	000s	%	000s	%	000s	%	000s	%	000s	%	000s	%	000s	%
The Sun	9229	19.6	3267	12.9	5962	27.3	5652	23.6	3577	15.5	5220	22.8	4009	16.5
Daily Mail	5979	12.7	3955	15.7	2024	9.3	2093	8.7	3886	16.8	3022	13.2	2957	12.2
Daily Mirror	5146	10.9	1990	7.9	3155	14.4	2318	9.7	2828	12.2	2727	11.9	2419	10.0
Daily Telegraph	2306	4.9	1967	7.8	339	1.6	702	2.9	1604	6.9	1268	5.5	1038	4.3
Daily Express	2181	4.6	1307	5.2	874	4.0	767	3.2	1414	6.1	1161	5.1	1020	4.2
Daily Star	1894	4.0	649	2.6	1245	5.7	1347	5.6	547	2.4	1362	6.0	533	2.2
The Times	1865	4.0	1635	6.5	230	1.1	894	3.7	971	4.2	1115	4.9	750	3.1
Metro	1498	3.2	973	3.9	525	2.4	1139	4.7	359	1.6	874	3.8	624	2.6
The Guardian	1332	2.8	1144	4.5	189	0.9	771	3.2	562	2.4	776	3.4	557	2.3
The Independent	584	1.2	497	2.0	87	0.4	308	1.3	276	1.2	370	1.6	214	0.9

19 Information from the National Readership Survey, June 2002–June 2003

- National Magazine Company is a subsidiary of the vast Hearst Corporation in America. It publishes seventeen high-circulation consumer magazines in the UK, including *Cosmopolitan* and *Esquire*.
- Future is a smaller company based in Bath specialising in film, computing and sports magazines, including fanzines such as *United*.

KEY TERM

Mode of address the way in which a text creates a relationship with its audience

ACTIVITY 3

1 Research the publishers and circulations of the magazines in Activity 2. Follow the link on Heinemann Hotlinks. Display your results in a table.

Magazine	Publisher	Circulation
OK		

2 Look at your tables from this activity and Activity 2. Which types of magazines have the highest and lowest circulations?

Analysing magazine covers



Magazine publishing is a hugely profitable and growing media industry. It is also very competitive. Your research in Activity 1 showed you some techniques used by magazines to address their audiences by capturing their interest on the shelf. Now you are going to look closely at a magazine cover and analyse its features. This is an excellent way to find out what messages a magazine is conveying to its audience.

To be successful a magazine must establish a close, personal and almost friendly relationship with its readers. Magazines are all about **mode of address**. This is often through the person featured in the text. On the cover in **2** the person is looking straight out at the reader; this is known as a *direct mode of address*. When the person is looking away, and therefore inviting the reader to look on, but to be less involved, the text is using an *indirect mode of address*. This gives clues about the type of magazine it is and the relationship it wants to have with its audience.

Now look at the annotations on **2**. You already know what *mode of address* means. Try to make sure that you understand the other terms in **bold** that are used in the annotations. It is important to use the correct terms when you analyse any media text. Other key terms that you might use when you analyse a magazine cover are:

- **seasonal theme**: when the colours and contents of a magazine relate to the time of year, e.g. red hearts and features on romance for St Valentine's Day
- **mise-en-scene**: the way in which every element of the text is arranged to create a meaning
- **anchorage text**: writing that fixes the meaning of an image, e.g. a caption
- **blurb**: factual information, often in small print.

TIP

Using the correct terms and language when you analyse a text is a really good way to get more marks.

The **price** is placed in an eye-catching 'star' to attract the eye and act as a persuasive technique.

The **slogan** tries to convince the reader that this magazine is better than its rivals.

The **central image** of Kym Marshall relies on the audience knowing that she was in the band Hearsay and married Jack Ryder from *EastEnders*. Kym is represented in a fashionable dress that shows off her figure – the **anchorage text** suggests that she has lost weight – and she uses **direct mode of address**, smiling into the eyes of the reader to share her happiness with them.

The **title** of the magazine connotes an up-to-the-minute feel, suggesting that readers will be reading the most recent events in the lives of the celebrities featured.

The word 'exclusive' is a **buzz word** suggesting that this magazine is the only one to cover this story.



© NOW/IPC Syndication

The arrow is a **graphic feature** to add interest to the question being posed.

Puffs at the bottom of the page suggest that the magazine will give fashion and beauty tips – assuming that the reader is concerned with their appearance.

The three **images** are linked by theme – they all feature stars and their babies – and by the story title which acts as **anchorage text**. The story relies on the audience knowing who the stars are and that they are now parents. It also assumes that readers want to know about the private lives of stars.

1 Analysing a magazine cover

ACTIVITY 4

Now have a go at analysing the magazine front cover in **3** yourself. *Hotdog* is a specialist film magazine aimed at 15–35-year-old males with an interest in film. Try to identify how the cover has been made to appeal to its audience.

- Remember to use the correct terms whenever you can.
- Look back at how the cover in **2** was analysed if you need help.



Hotdog's readers are mainly male filmgoers aged 15 to 35 years

Who reads magazines?

Considering the ways in which audiences read or watch different media texts is a very important part of media studies. The best way to start is with YOU, since so many texts are aimed at people like you. You are part of the powerful 14–18-year-old audience, and media producers are very interested to know what you like and what you want.

Can you think why your age group is so powerful? The main reason is that, even though you don't usually earn large sums of money, what you do earn is virtually all **disposable income** – there is only you to spend it on. After all, most young people do not have to pay for food or housing, so media producers want you to spend your money on their products. Producers also want readers with spending power to attract advertisers who subsidise the cost of production. The money advertisers pay for space in print-based texts is used to reduce the selling price. Without **subsidisation**, print-based media texts would cost over twice as much.

KEY TERMS

Disposable income the money someone has left to spend after they have paid for essentials such as housing and food

Subsidisation reducing the cover price of a media text such as a magazine or newspaper by selling advertising space

When and how do people consume media texts?

Audiences consume, that is, watch, read or listen to, media products in a whole range of situations and places, sometimes while doing other things, sometimes with focused attention. This is sometimes known as *pattern of consumption*. How is the girl in **4** consuming the text?.

reinforcing female **stereotypes** – for example, girls and women can make themselves ill trying to look like the models in the pictures. What do you think?

Age

Try to avoid making sweeping statements about the age of a target audience, such as: 'This text is aimed at teenagers'. You might find the following breakdown helpful:

Under 5 6–8 9–12 13–15 16–18 19–25 26–40 41–60 Over 60

ACTIVITY 8

Imagine you are a media producer considering at which audience to aim your latest product. What do you know about people of different ages?

List and discuss the probable lifestyle, likes and dislikes of people in these age groups: 6–8; 16–18; 25–40; over 60.

Ask yourself about their hobbies, their favourite night out, the TV programmes they watch, etc. How might a media producer use this information?

People over 60 are likely to: have low disposable income; have similar, non-active lifestyles; not enjoy violence; enjoy films and programmes from the past.

When target audiences are described in this way, the various categories are being stereotyped. The description of people over 60 in Activity 8 may be true for many people, but it is important to remember that some over-60s still earn high salaries, run marathons, enjoy thrillers and go to pop concerts!

Ethnicity

Although ethnicity is not always relevant, the racial or religious background of an audience may be a factor affecting what a text contains. For example, *Asiana Wedding* is a magazine that targets Asian women.



5 Ethnicity is a major factor in the audience targeting of *Asiana Wedding*

KEY TERMS

Stereotype how a certain group of people is represented

Values and aspirations the ideas and aims that are important to people and that they aim at or wish for

ACTIVITY 9

Find out what magazines are most popular with people in your school. Try to ask students who represent a mix of ages, genders and ethnic backgrounds. What links can you see between these factors and the magazines people enjoy? Present your findings in the form of a chart, graph or table and discuss in class.

Lifestyle

Being able to discuss the possible lifestyle and habits of an audience is important. Try to consider the **values and aspirations** (ideology) of the audience of a text you are analysing. Media producers research their audiences well, to find out what kinds of things are important to them, so that the messages in their texts will appeal to them and make them respond positively to them. Ask yourself how the text highlights (and perhaps reinforces) those values.

Look again at the front cover of *Now* magazine on page 85.

- It suggests that the audience might be anxious about their appearance – note the '8 pages of holiday fashion' and Kym's 'diet secrets'.
- The audience are obviously very interested in stories about stars and celebrities, and probably use pictures of them to provide role models of beauty, fame and success.
- The magazine assumes that readers will want to know as much about the personal lives of celebrities as possible, in this case featuring stars and their babies.



6 *Mizz* magazine, November 2003

© MIZZ/IPC Syndication

ACTIVITY 10

Look closely at the front cover of *Mizz* in **6**. Write bullet points to suggest:

- the likely audience of the magazine
- the kinds of features that might be appealing to this audience.

You need to decide whether to do your Practical Production as part of a group of up to four or on your own. For some types of practical production, such as video-making, it is virtually impossible to work alone. For the other types, group work can be helpful: two or three views and sets of ideas are likely to make for a more interesting final product. You can find more details about working in a group in the introduction.

Writing an analysis and evaluation of your work

Another difference between your GCSE production and professionally produced material is that once the editor of *Smash Hits* has published the magazine, they do not have to write an account of how good they think it is. But you do!

The analysis and evaluation (also known as a *supporting account*, *written evaluative report* or *evaluative commentary*) form a very important part of the work you will do and of your marks (see the example on page 191). If you are working in a group, it is doubly important because it will show the individual contribution you made towards the work (see pages 10–11).

The written evaluation should fall within the word count limits given by your awarding body (see pages 10–11). It should include:

- A clear opening explanation of what you were intending to produce and the target audience at whom you aimed your production.
- Some evidence that you have thought about, and preferably researched, your target audience and the 'market' for your product.
- Your own comments on the decisions that were made at each stage of production and why those decisions were made. For example, if you had three video sequences of a particular section of your film and only chose one to include in the final edit – *why* were the other two rejected? These comments on the decision-making process will be very important for your teacher when the marks are being given because it shows how much you have learnt from doing the production work.
- In a group production, a clear account of all the things you were responsible for.
- Links between your product and professionally produced work of a similar nature. How and why is yours different?
- A final evaluation of the completed production, saying how successful you think it is, what you would change if you had the chance to do it again and a statement about what you have learnt as a result of the work.
- An appendix to your written piece which includes pre-production work such as storyboards, questionnaires, scripts and work schedules.

You should *not* include:

- A string of excuses about your teacher failing to give you the right camera/computer/battery.
- A minute-by-minute account of every button that was pushed and tripod that was carried – what examiners call the 'dear Diary' approach. You only have a limited number of words, not enough to waste describing unimportant details.

Research

An important part of pre-production is the research stage. Before you rush headlong into designing your advertising campaign or shooting your pop video, you will need to think about the content of your product and the audience you are aiming it at.

Any company launching a new teen magazine in the real world would first find out about the interests and needs of the teenagers they hope to persuade to buy their magazine. They would also analyse very carefully their target audience and the products already in the market.

For some types of product you may find it useful to do some market research. This need not necessarily take the form of detailed questionnaires – though that is a possibility. But you should at the very least try out any ideas you have on some representative sample of your target audience to gauge their reaction. You should then write up what you have learnt from the research in your analysis.

Another part of your research will probably have been covered during your GCSE Media Studies course. This is a study of the way in which media texts like yours are put together. In other words, you should be familiar with the *media language* you are about to use. An important part of producing a good practical production is the extent to which you have shown your teacher and the examiner that you understand and can use effectively the *codes* and *conventions* of your chosen medium.

What does this mean in practice? Suppose you are producing a radio magazine programme aimed at a teenage market about the latest film releases. If all you do is sit down in front of a tape recorder and talk in a monotone about a few films you have seen recently, you will not have used appropriate media language. A professional programme of this sort would include interviews, extracts of dialogue from some films, and a synopsis of what the films are about and who appears in them. The presentation would be slick, with no long pauses or 'ums' and 'errs'. Usually some sort of outline script guides the way the programme develops.

Choosing your medium

With your research completed, you now need to decide which type or types of media technology you are going to use to complete your production work. Ideally you will have tried your hand at a variety of print, audio and video projects during your course so you will know your own expertise and preferences. If not, it is important as part of pre-production to practise with the type of equipment you are going to use. If you start trying to shoot a video or record a radio programme for the first time during the production phase you are less likely to do yourself full justice.

Making a video

Video is arguably the most exciting technology to use for your practical work. It is really a multi-technology because you will be dealing with pictures, sounds and maybe graphic designs too.

For these reasons it is also the most complex. To get the best results you must be sure to plan every stage in the greatest possible detail. Because there are a number of different stages and activities involved in making a video production, it is a good choice for a group. Everyone will certainly have enough chance to make their own individual contribution.

One thing you should be clear about right from the outset: small is beautiful. A thirty-second advertisement can involve a tremendous amount of hard work and planning. It is better to think in terms of a short but highly crafted video than a ten- or fifteen-minute epic. The longer the video, the less attention is paid to getting each shot as tightly composed and appropriately edited as it ought to be.

Pre-production

Storyboarding your ideas

Designing and drawing the storyboard form a vital part of the pre-production phase. A storyboard is the visual part of a film set down on paper or computer screen to look like a strip of pictures from a comic. Alongside the pictures or drawings are notes which give details of any dialogue to be spoken, any music soundtrack or sound effects, camera movements like pans or tracks, movements made by actors and sometimes notes about costume, props and, if appropriate, lighting.

Why is a storyboard important?

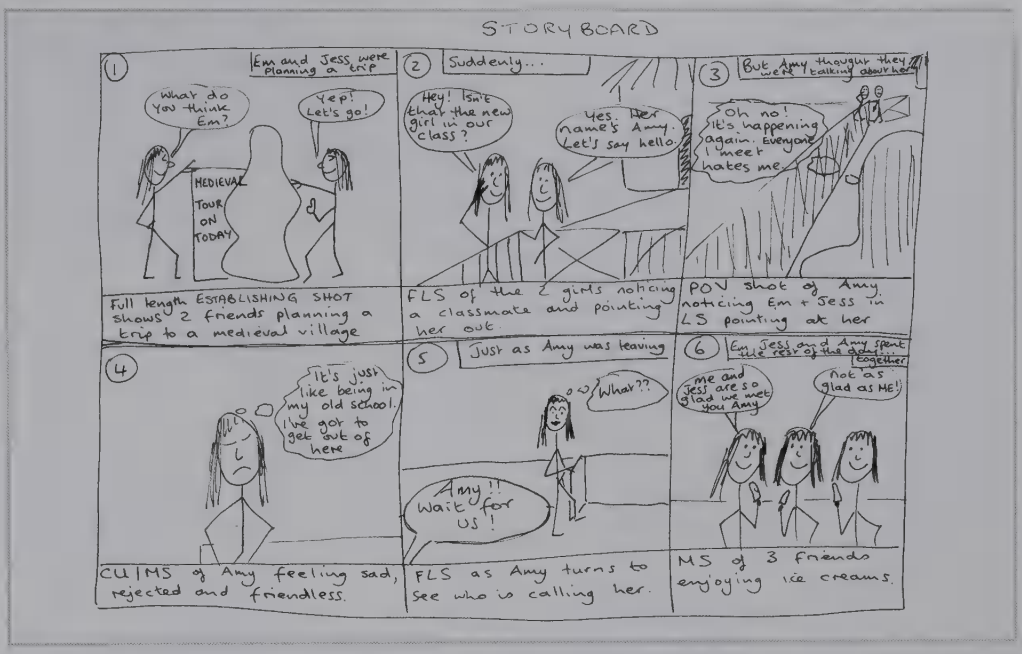
- To get visual ideas out of your head and onto paper/screen: this is often the most difficult stage of the whole filming process. Storyboarding forces you to clarify your ideas and think carefully about how to get your meaning across to the audience through pictures.
- To plan the order of the shots in a sequence: think where the camera will be placed and what movements your actors will be making.
- To save time on location: if you arrive with no idea of how the film is to be shot you will be wasting everyone's time.

Storyboarding a film

If your school has a software package such as Storyboard you can use that to storyboard your film. However, a paper version of your storyboard will do just as well. Whatever version of a storyboard you use, it should contain columns with the information shown in chart **1**.

Visuals	Shot type	Words	Music/FX	Timing
You will need to draw into this box exactly what you want the camera operator to see and film. The drawing does not need to be beautifully finished, but it must show what it is that you want to happen during the filming of this particular shot.	This is a quick back-up to your drawing in the Visuals box. It will use the common abbreviations to indicate which shot types and camera angles you wish to be used. See pages 22–24 and 39 for details of shot types.	This box will contain any words of dialogue or voice-over that accompany the shot in the visuals box.	The music is likely to run beneath a number of shots, so this column may have an arrow continuing from the boxes above showing which shots it is covering – and noting precisely which shot it begins with and at which shot it ends. The same may be true for special effects, or there may be a short noise which only occurs in this shot.	In this column show the duration of the shot or sequence.

1 How to lay out a storyboard sheet for a film



This student's completed storyboard for a photo-comic could be adapted to make a short film

Production

The production stage involves making the ideas on your storyboard into shots taken by a camera crew. You not have to shoot everything in exactly the same order as it comes on your storyboard, especially if it involves different locations. You can put things into the right order in the edit at the post-production stage.

Shot log

To save you time when you come to edit, it is a good idea always to keep a **shot log** (see the example in **3**). If you are using a sophisticated camera, you might be able to record the time code on the logging sheet, to give you an exact reference in seconds for each shot on the tape.

If, as is more likely, you are working with simpler equipment, you need to log how long the shot is and a *cumulative time*, that is, how many minutes of tape have been shot in all. This will help you find them more quickly when you come to edit. In this case it is a good idea to use a *clapper board*. All you need is a small blackboard and chalk, or a white board and marker pen. Every time you roll the camera, focus first on the clapper board on which you have written the exact shot number and take number.

TIP

If you can access *MediaStage* software, create a performance of your storyboard to refine your planning. A print out of your screen shots could be used as evidence.

KEY TERM

Shot log a list of all the shots you take in the order in which they occur on the source tape

Camera operator: JG
Camera: Canon XM 1

Location: Lydford
Date: 4th June 04

Shot no.	Set up: ELS/LS/MLS/MS/MCU/CU/ECU	Take Good (G) or No good (NG)?	Notes on shot content	Time code
1	ELS	NG	Tripod knocked	00: 31: 14
1	ELS	G	Shot down over the valley, showing village	00: 31: 27
2	LS	G	Tilt down church spire to door	00: 31: 46

Your shot log should look like this

KEY TERMS

Ambient sound the sounds of everything going on around the person who is speaking

Edit Decision List (EDL) or **Editing Script List** written statement of what is to go in the film and where it is to fit

Editor the person responsible for deciding the order in which shots and sequences are assembled at the post-production stage

Sequence a series of individual shots joined together by the editor

Synchronised sound the words spoken match the lip movements of the speaker

speaker you will pick up a lot of **ambient sound**. Sometimes you will want some ambient sound; if your actors are sitting on a beach you might want to hear the sound of waves and the wind. However, you need to control the level of those sounds so that they do not drown out the voice.

You will almost certainly need to set up shots that are no wider than a medium close-up, because the camera microphone will then be close enough to pick up a reasonable level of sound from the voice. If you are in a noisy environment, such as a busy street, you should move as close to the speaker as you reasonably can.

Using a microphone which is separate from the camera

The advantage of using an external microphone is that you can get it much closer to the person speaking while having the camera set at the type of shot you would ideally like – even if this is a long shot. Professional film crews have someone who does nothing else but record the sound. This sound recordist may use all sorts of different types of microphone, depending on the situation that is being filmed and the effect the director wants to achieve.

Post-production

The individual shots recorded during the production phase only make sense when they are joined together into **sequences**. It may help you to think of this as being like words building up into sentences. Each individual word may have some meaning. When you hear the word 'house' you have some picture in your mind of a building in which people live. But if words are added either side of it, the meaning is much clearer. 'The old house was falling down' gives you a much more detailed image to visualise. And of course if different words are put either side of 'house', the meaning is completely different: 'the glass house shimmered in the sun'. In exactly the same way, if you change the order in which your shots are combined into a sequence, the meaning can change.

Joining together the various shots into sequences is the job of the **editor**. Editing is a vitally important part of the whole film-making process. The director will very often work alongside the editor because the choices made at the editing stage can completely change the meaning of the finished piece.

Edit Decision List or Editing Script List

The first thing to do at post-production is to look at all the material you have shot and start to think about how it will all fit together. You cannot change the type of shot you or your group filmed, but for the edit you have to decide:

- how much of each shot is going to be included in the finished film
- the order in which the shots will be joined together into sequences.

When you have the basic building blocks in place, i.e. all the shots are in the right order and of the right length, then it is time to think of the finer details, such as transitions, visual effects and post-production sound.

Transitions

You get from one shot to the next by means of a *transition*. There are five main types.

- **The cut:** one shot is instantly followed on the screen by another. This is by far the most common transition. It is so common, in fact, that when it happens you hardly notice because you are so used to it.

All the other transitions are much more noticeable, so if you are thinking of using something other than a cut you should ask yourself: *What will that sort of transition add to my film that using a cut would not?*

> **TIP**
>
> If you can access *MediaStage* software, you can practise cuts and other editing techniques.

- **The jump cut:** the effect of a jump cut is to make the character on the screen appear to 'jump' from one place to another. It also makes the person watching jump because it disrupts the illusion that they are watching real life. A jump cut looks more like magic!
- **The dissolve:** the first shot gradually dissolves and is replaced by the second shot. There will be a moment when both shots are on the screen, before the first one gradually fades away.
- **The fade:** this can either be a *fade in*, which is where a blank screen is gradually filled by the incoming shot, or a *fade out* where the shot gradually fades away leaving a blank screen. The fade is usually used to show that, in the case of a fade in, a new scene is beginning, or with a fade out, that an ending of some sort has been reached.
- **The wipe:** the effect of a wipe is to see the first shot chased off the screen by the next shot. Wipes can use all sorts of different patterns to get one shot off and the next on. The incoming shot can burst through in the shape of a star or the outgoing shot can appear to swirl round and disappear like water running down a plug hole. Wipes will definitely draw attention to the fact that you are going from one shot to the next. Only use them if you have a *very* good reason.

Adding visual effects

Once again, unless there is a very good reason, avoid using too many visual effects. You should only use them when you have a clear idea of what effect you hope they will have on the viewer. Common visual effects you could use, if your editing software includes the option, include:

- desaturated colour: this gives a slightly washed out effect to the picture; you can even take out all the colour and make a black-and-white picture
- saturated colour: the colours are very vivid and unnatural
- slow motion
- fast motion.

Post-production sound

There are a few sound sources which you can think about adding to the synchronised sound you will already have recorded.

- **Voice-over sound**: this needs to be dubbed onto any picture sequences. Documentaries and advertisements often use a lot of voice-over.
- **Sound effects** will usually be added to the soundtrack at the dubbing stage. Sound effects can be further sub-divided into two types:
  - Those sounds which directly match actions or events on the screen, for example a door slamming or a glass breaking.

- Those sounds which are about the scene but do not match anything actually shown. For example, the sound of birds singing might accompany a scene set in the countryside, or traffic noise and car horns dubbed onto a scene in a city centre flat. These sound effects are called *ambient sounds*. They appear on the soundtrack to give greater depth to the illusion that what is shown is real rather than something set up to be filmed.

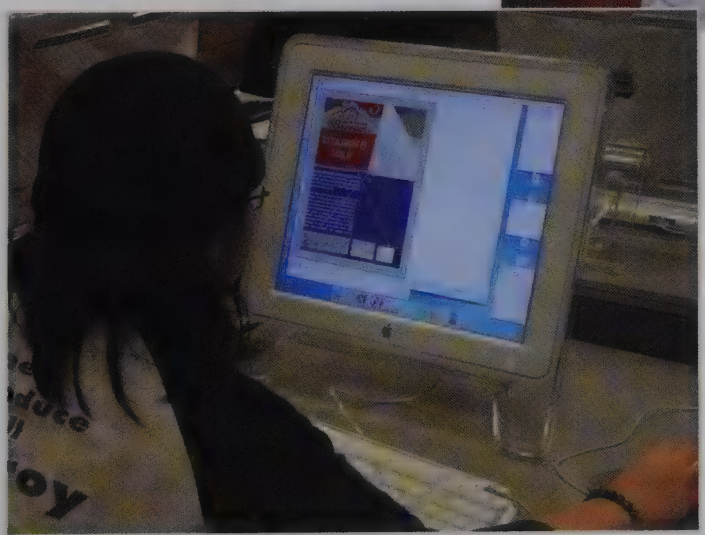
- **Music** is the final sound to be added to your film in post-production. Your choice of music will be very important. Music is used to make the audience feel certain emotions as they watch the action on screen. In high-budget film or television productions, specially composed music will be commissioned for the soundtrack. Alternatively the rights to use well known pop songs can be bought.

The rough cut

With your EDL written, you are now ready to make a *rough cut* of your film. This is a bit like a first draft of a piece of writing. You need to implement all the decisions from the EDL and then sit back and view the rough cut a few times.

Until quite recently, editing was a very time-consuming business, mainly because any changes meant starting from the beginning and editing everything again. With new digital software packages that are cheap and easily available, editing can really become a drafting process.





7 Stages in the production of a video

It is not possible here to give detailed instructions about the process of using editing software because this will be different from one package to the next. If you are not familiar with the way the software works you will need to explore it before beginning your rough cut.

When viewing your rough cut, you need to think about these factors, and write about them in your analysis.

- **The length of time each shot is held on screen:** It is only when you see your rough cut that you will know whether your EDL got this right. If a shot contains one line spoken to camera by your actor then it cannot be shorter than the actual words being delivered. But is there a half-second pause that you could get rid of at the beginning to make the sequence flow more smoothly? Or does the shot end much too abruptly? Maybe an extra half second would make it less rushed? Remember – you can work as exactly as one twenty-fourth of a second so it pays to get the length of shot exactly right.
- **The order in which the shots occur:** Although you may have thought the order was correct when you were writing your EDL, on viewing them you may find that you can change them around, or even lose some altogether.
- **How well any visual effects, music or sound you have added work:** Does the music create the right mood for your film? Are the slow-motion sequences too slow or not slow enough? Do not be afraid to change things and see if they can be made to work more effectively – that is why you made a rough cut.
- **Have you got titles and end credits right?** Often you can leave the design of a title sequence until after you have viewed the rough. The same will be true for the end credits. But you will need to make sure everyone who has worked on or helped in the making of your film gets a mention.

The fine cut

Now that you have made all the notes on the changes to be made, you are ready to return to the editing software and make the final version – the fine cut – of your film.

Making a radio programme

In comparison to video-making, recording an audio product is potentially a much simpler process. It is possible to produce almost broadcast-quality results with relatively inexpensive equipment.

The type of recording gear you use will probably be dictated by the resources your school can provide. These days most radio stations use digital equipment, so interviews will be recorded on mini-disc players which slip into a journalist's coat pocket. But not long ago they were still recording on audio cassettes or open spool tape. Even if you only have access to audio-cassette machines, you can still make a radio programme which sounds pretty much like the real thing.

Pre-production

Once you have completed your research you will need to write a programme outline and then a running order of the items which are to appear. It is important to show that you can use a full range of audio sources. Making a 'top ten' music hits tape, with you as the DJ, may be easy but it will not challenge you very much. If you are making a radio programme you should think about a 5–10-minute section of a radio-style

- *Presentation:* How much of the publication is given over to photos? Are any drawings used? How many different styles of print are used? Are the colours bright and brash or muted and subtle?
- *Audience:* What kind of reader are the products aimed at? How do you know?
- *Front pages or covers:* These are a crucial part of any publication. They are the way potential readers are 'grabbed' as they look along the racks in newsagents. What does the front cover tell you about the sort of readership being targeted? What idea of the content of the magazine does the cover give? How does the combination of pictures and words encourage people to buy the publication? What kind of lifestyle is being catered for by this magazine?
- *Advertising:* newspapers and magazines need to sell advertising space to help cover the cost of production. What products are being advertised and what does this tell you about the sorts of readers being targeted?

Production

When you have decided on your target audience, draw up your production schedule. This is a list of all the things which need to be done, who will be doing them and the deadlines which need to be met.

Stage 1: Planning the content

Draw up a list of all the articles you wish to include and how many pages you can realistically produce in the time you have been given. It is much better to produce fewer high-quality pages than a lot of articles which are poorly written and badly laid out because you have tried to do too much in too short a space of time.

As a guideline, think in terms of each individual being responsible for two double-page spreads. The person responsible for the cover could count that as the equivalent of a double page. Anyone designing a full-page advertisement could also substitute that for a double-page spread.

Once you have a clear outline of what the finished product will look like, divide up the writing and photography tasks among the members of your group.

Stage 2: Writing the articles

You might be able to write some articles immediately, but others will need to be researched or require an interview to be arranged. You might decide at this stage that one of the group will act as a picture researcher. Their job will be to search the Internet and collect a range of pictures which might be useful for each article so that a wide choice is available at the page design stage.

Ideally you will have two *production meetings* where the whole group come together and review the work.

The first one should be halfway through the writing stage. The main purpose will be to check that everyone is running to time, and if not, take immediate action to make sure any problems are overcome. Are you able to extend your deadlines? If not, are you going to have to drop some articles? Will there be sufficient content left to ensure each group member can show how much they know about producing whatever product you have chosen to make? Are the pictures that have been collected appropriate?

The second production meeting will come at the end of the process of writing. You should all read each other's work in a productive, critical way and suggest any

amendments which might be necessary. At this stage you should make a mock-up of the front page or cover and decide on a title for the paper or magazine. Anyone who has been designing a full-page advert should present their ideas at this meeting. Finally, you need to list any photographs that need to be taken.

Stage 3: Photo shoots

The photograph for the front cover of a magazine should be very carefully planned. Photographs used in advertisements also need to be thought through and a variety of alternatives taken from which the best one can be chosen.

For a professional fashion/advertisement shoot there will be a number of people involved:

- art director (in overall charge of the shoot)
- photographer (takes the photos and makes suggestions to the art director)
- two or three photographer's assistants to carry gear and set up lights
- stylist (to supervise costume and make-up)
- the client or their representative (to check they are happy with what is being photographed)
- the model or models.

You will probably have a much smaller crew, but you should certainly involve more than one person. Above all you need to look at every single detail of the images that you take to make sure that the photograph is conveying exactly the right message to your audience.

When posing any models for each photograph, use the following checklist:

- *Posture:* how will I pose the model? Lazing on a sofa will give a relaxed feel to the image; sitting upright in an office chair will give a more formal feel.
- *Facial expression:* do I want to create a moody look? Or do I want a happy, relaxed feel to the shot?
- *Costume:* what someone wears tells other people a great deal about them. Make sure that each piece of your model's clothing has been selected to get across the chosen image.
- *Setting and props:* think about the message that the setting of your shot will convey, and any props you use. Is the school playing field *really* the best setting for your jeans advert – or have you just gone there because it is easy? Is your teacher's N-reg. Fiesta going to add to the 'cool image' you are trying to create?

Once you have all of the things on that checklist sorted out, your next job is to compose them within the frame of your camera. Although there is no hard-and-fast set of rules about what makes a good photograph, the following composition guidelines might offer you a starting point for making interesting images.

Using thirds

Where will you place significant elements in your picture? Research has shown that viewers look first at the human face – especially the eyes – and any points of high contrast. Photographers often talk about the *principle of thirds*. When looking through the viewfinders of their cameras, they imagine a grid formed by two vertical and two horizontal lines which divide the picture into thirds. They then place key elements of the composition, often using a one-third to two-thirds proportion. Look at photograph **10** and think about the way it has used thirds for its composition.



10 This photo was composed using the principle of thirds

Lines of movement

Photographs are often thought to have a stronger composition if the objects in them are seen as 'moving into' the picture – see **11**.



11 The men are looking into the right of this frame

Diagonals and horizontals

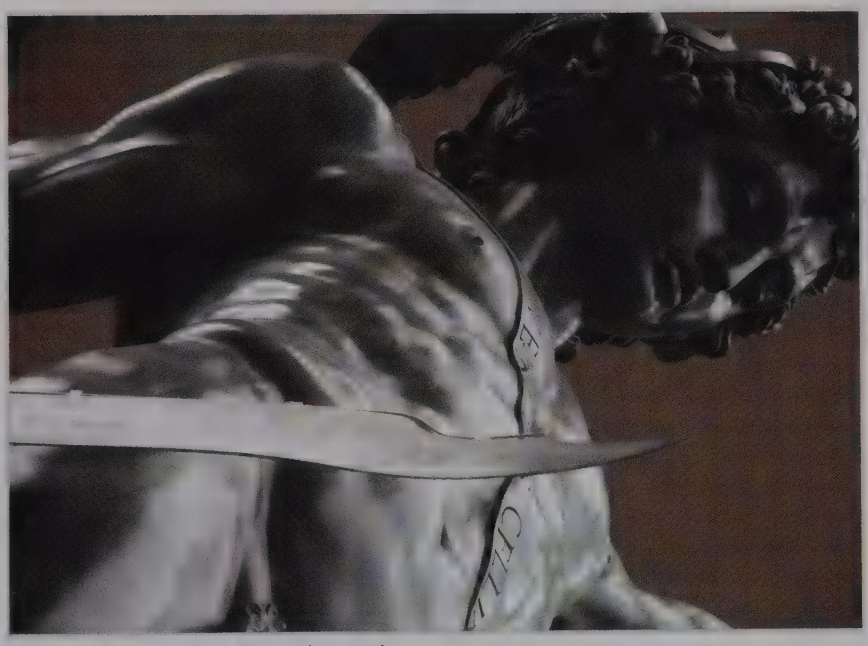
Diagonal lines in compositions are said to be more dynamic than horizontal ones. How have lines been used in the composition in image **12**?



12 St Marks Square, Venice

Angle

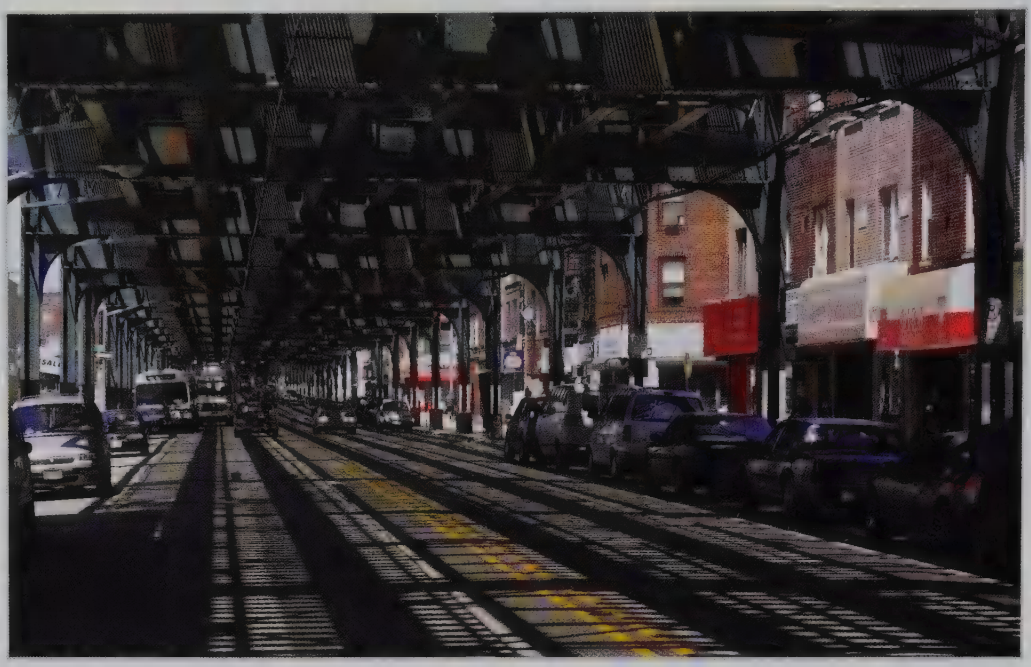
Most photographs are taken at eye level. Taking them from above or below, as in **13**, your subject can be another way of creating visual impact.



13 This photo was taken from a low angle

Light

Getting the lighting right can mean more than just making sure there is enough light. The factors mentioned for video production on page 175 apply equally to lighting for a still photograph. Strong sunlight coming through the overhead railway in Brooklyn adds to the composition of photograph **14**.



14 Lighting is an important feature of this composition

Post-production

With your articles written and imagery produced, you now need to decide the order in which articles will appear and – crucially – how they are to be laid out on the page. It is the presentation of your publication that would sell it in the real world.

Using a computer software package at the page design stage will obviously be a great advantage as you can quickly and easily manipulate both your written work and your images. Being able to see the effect of changes in layout and font makes experimentation easy. However, you can still use older methods of cutting up and pasting your work directly onto paper. Remember: you should be thinking about the *appropriateness* of your design to your intended audience as well as how to grab and keep a reader's attention.

Some hints on layout

- Look at a wide range of different publications and make notes of layout features which you think would be good to incorporate in your production.
- Use a page grid to help you in your page design, even if you decide to break out of it. This is how all page designs in professional publications start out – see the example in **15**.
- The various parts of the design do not have to be straight or orderly. Scattered letters can add to the dynamic look of the page. However, if you use straight lines and columns, make sure they are just that!
- Use blank space. It can provide contrast in your design. If everything is spaced out evenly it can look bland and uninteresting.
- Titles set on a diagonal can add emphasis and look more dynamic.
- If your production is using a double-page spread which is to be folded and stapled, make a small dummy version that includes the same number of pages. Number the pages, then separate them to see which page goes with which on the paste-up. You can see the page combinations for a sixteen-page booklet in image **16**.